BOUND & BROKEN

When three siblings vanish into a sentient book discovered in a mysterious carnival tent, they're transported into mythic realms shaped by memory, fear, and forgotten tales. As they journey through collapsing worlds, resist the roles written for them, and uncover the truth of an ancient entity known as the Storywright, they must fight to reclaim their identities—and write their own way home.

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FADE IN BLACK:

A CHILD'S VOICE, barely there. A whisper caught in paper.

CHILD (V.O.)
(sings song, broken)
Names are knots. Names are thread.
Pull too hard—you disappear.

A LOW CREAK. Like a book opening its spine.

DARKNESS PEELS BACK—

INT. THE BOOK - UNDEFINED SPACE - NIGHT

Not a place. A feeling.

Ink drifts through the air like ash. Letters fall apart before they land. The ground shifts, unfinished, as if the world forgot what it was meant to be.

LEO LONDON (13), haunted before his time. Thin, alert, with storm colored eyes that scan the dark like he's searching for a way out he once knew but no longer remembers. A boy beginning to sense he has forgotten something vital.

He blinks. Breath fogs, though there's no cold. He looks down at his hands.

They are smudged. Not dirty, blurred. The edges of his fingers soften, as if the world is losing interest in keeping him whole.

LEO
Hello?

His voice echoes once. Then again. Then not at all.

The silence presses closer.

Something MOVES in the dark. Not running. Not stalking. Waiting.

Leo takes a step back.

The ground responds late, like it's deciding whether to catch him.

A SHAPE forms ahead—tall, draped in stitched pages. Its face never settles. Letters slide where eyes should be.

THE EXECUTIONER (O.S.)
You came back wrong.

Leo shakes his head, panic building.

LEO
I didn’t come back. I didn’t—

He stops. The words don’t line up.

The thing glides closer. With every inch it gains, the air tightens.

Leo’s wrist burns. A SYMBOL flickers across it, etched blurred light. He clutches at it.

THE EXECUTIONER (O.S.)
Say your name.

Leo opens his mouth. Nothing comes out.
The symbol BRIGHTENS. HUNGRY.

Leo squeezes his eyes shut.

LEO
(shouting)
Ava!

The symbol falters.

The stitched pages SHIVER, irritated.

THE EXECUTIONER (O.S.)
That name is not yours to keep.

The darkness surges.

A HAND GRABS LEO’S ARM. YANKS HIM BACK—

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. LONDON HOUSE - LEO’S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Leo jerks upright, GASPING. Sweat-soaked. Trembling.

The room is dim, lit by fractured moonlight through worn blinds. Posters peeling. Clothes on the floor. A desk overrun with stacked sketchbooks and broken pencils.

ON THE WALL: a FADING FAMILY PHOTO. The entire London family... parents, grandparents, children. Smiling. Unaware it would be their last picture together.

A small shadowbox near his bed contains a FIRE DEPARTMENT BADGE and a newspaper clipping with blurred headlines: "Family Tragedy on Route 17."

On the floor beside his bed: a CHILD'S HAND-KNIT BLANKET. Unfinished. A corner still trailing yarn.

Leo presses his palm to his wrist. Nothing there.

He swings his legs off the bed.

On his nightstand: a HALF-DRAWN PICTURE. Crude pencil lines. Three figures holding hands in a place with no sky. One figure is scratched out. Erased so hard the paper tore.

Leo stares at it. He doesn't remember drawing it.

He reaches out—

A WHISPER OF STATIC. Like a page being turned somewhere far away.

Leo looks toward his door. The sound stops.

LEO
(under his breath)
I'm awake.

He lies back down. Pulls the blanket up tight.

His eyes stay open. Wide.

The CHILD'S VOICE from earlier returns, closer now. Sadder.

CHILD (V.O.)
(sings song, broken)
Break the story—it bleeds. Finish it—someone disappears.

FADE OUT.

INT. LONDON HOUSE - LIVING ROOM / KITCHEN NOOK - MORNING

Muted light seeps through half-drawn curtains.

CARTER LONDON (18) stands in silence. Lean, hoodie half-zipped, hair still damp from a rushed shower, with a kind of tired in his eyes that doesn't sleep off.

He stares at a cluttered side table. Unopened envelopes. Final notices. A hand-written sign taped to the lamp: DO NOT THROW OUT.

Deep exhale as he opens a drawer and pulls out a battered METAL LOCKBOX.

He hesitates, then unlocks it with a key from his neck.

Inside:

— A faded ticket stub: “GIDEON’S CARNIVAL OF ENDINGS & WONDERS”

— $18.57 in wrinkled bills

— two wedding rings, worn smooth

— A photo of the family at a fair. All of them. Smiling.

Carter stares at the ticket. Frowns. He doesn’t remember keeping it.

Footsteps above. The house shifts.

He closes the box. Locks it, and slides it back into the drawer.

CUT TO:

INT. LONDON HOUSE - KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER

The house is too quiet. Still learning how to hold a family that’s falling apart.

Faded floral wallpaper. A fridge held together with magnets, family photos and old school drawings. A calendar still flipped to the wrong month.

Carter stands at the stove, sleeves pushed up, burning eggs he doesn’t want. He drops bread in the toaster, then leans over the sink, staring at the backyard like it owes him an answer.

AVA LONDON (17) leans in the doorway. Slender but solid, posture half-defensive. Dyed-black hair in a grown-out cut, eyes dark, reflective, sketchbook tucked under her arm, headphones loose around her neck. She watches him, unreadable.

Leo enters, hoodie swallowing his thin frame, eyes bruised by another night without sleep. He flinches at the sunlight but says nothing. He sits, hands buried in his pockets.

A beat. Carter glances at him.

CARTER
You look like hell.

LEO
Didn’t sleep.

AVA
(flat)
That makes what, four days?

Leo shrugs.

Carter scrapes eggs onto three plates, slides one in front of Leo, another across the table without looking up.

Leo closes his eyes.

LEO
Something's coming.

CARTER
Don’t start.

LEO
I’m not starting anything.

CARTER
You sound like Mom.

Silence hardens. Ava shifts uncomfortably.

AVA
She said it too. Before the crash.

CARTER
I know what she said.

LEO
You don’t believe her.

CARTER
No. I don’t. Because she left us.

AVA
That’s not fair.

CARTER
None of this is fair. And yet we still have to eat.

Leo gently pushes his plate away.

LEO
I’m not hungry.

Ava snags the milk, pours a glass and retreats back down the hall. Leo gets up and follows her.

Carter stands where he is. Alone with the painful memory. His eyes start to swell as he fights to hold back his emotion.

CLANK, the fridge hums, strained, uneven, breaking the silence.

CUT TO:

INT. LONDON HOUSE - AVA'S ROOM - DAY

A cracked ceiling. Thumbtacked sketches form constellations on peeling wallpaper. Sunlight pours in through a double window as a desk lamp, dim, hums on a small desk.

Ava sits cross legged on her bed, sketchbook balanced on one knee, the other foot bouncing to a rhythm only she can hear.

The room is lived in, not messy, just full. Books stacked like barricades. A cracked mug of cold tea. Half finished canvases leaned against the wall.

Her phone glows. A string of unread messages. ON SCREEN: a string of texts: ... "U ok?" ... "Call me?" ... "Ava come out. Just for a bit."

She turns it face-down.

Picks up a pencil. Draws. Erases. Draws again. Faster now.

The lines fight her. Shapes wrong. Emotions getting in the way. The pencil snaps.

She doesn’t flinch. Just breathes.

Crosses the room to the desk. Pulls open a drawer. Rummages through tangled earbuds, dried-out pens, a tiny tin of watercolor pans.

Her hand pauses on a folded flyer. Bold type: "COLLEGE PORTFOLIO PREP - SUMMER INTENSIVE." She stares at it, then rips it. Once. Twice. Tiny pieces now. She lets them fall into the trash.

Goes back to the bed. Sits. Sketchbook open again.

A single page. Empty.

She starts drawing again.

A low beat of music from her headphones. She doesn’t put them on.

Her pencil moves. Ink-stained fingers working like they’re remembering something her heart won’t say.

CLOSE ON THE SKETCH: Three figures. A boy holding a feather. A girl with a crown made of branches. The third is harder to place. Half-shadowed. Half-fire.

She adds a door behind them. Locked.

FAINTLY, FROM SOMEWHERE ELSE IN THE HOUSE: A WHISPER. Paper shifting.

She stops. Listens. Nothing.

INT. LONDON HOUSE - HALLWAY FOYER - LATER

A shaft of winter light slices through the old hallway foyer. Dust spirals. There is a loud knock at the door.

Leo runs in from another room and opens it. No one there.

He sees a POSTER tacked to the porch rail. Damp at the edges. Elegant script curls across the top: "GIDEON'S CARNIVAL OF ENDINGS & WONDERS — ONE NIGHT ONLY."

A blurred image of a striped tent. Beneath it, smaller letters: "Return what was forgotten. Remember what was taken."

Leo steps back in and closes the door. The flyer and a small bundle of mail in his hand.

Footsteps echo down from the upstairs landing. Ava appears, wearing one of their mom's old sweaters, too big, sleeves swallowed.

LEO
(holding up a flier)
This was tacked to the porch?

She reads it.

AVA (O.S.)
That's some creepy marketing.

Leo doesn't answer. His eyes are locked on the ink. It moves. Barely. Like it's breathing.

Then—

The feather under his shirt TINGLES.

INT. LONDON HOUSE - LEO'S BEDROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Leo rushes in. Pulls the feather out. It HUMS softly. Warmer.

He holds it near the flyer.

A WHISPER of STATIC.

Something flickers behind his eyes: A FLASH: of the BOOK'S WORLD, stitched pages, flickering symbols, a WHITE TOWER burning.

He gasps. Drops the feather.

CUT TO:

EXT. TOWN - LATER

A WHISTLE BLOWS—

Creaking WAGONS emerge at the far end of the town. Carnival WORKERS, vintage vests, smeared makeup, empty eyes, begin unloading faded tents.

Locals step outside. Curious. Confused.

KIDS point and cheer. PARENTS start snapping photos.

LITTLE GIRL (O.S.)
Mommy, it never left. It just forgot to show up last year.

The mother freezes. Looks down at her daughter.

MOTHER
(soft)
... Right.

She glances back at the carnival with no memory of it.

CUT TO:

EXT. ROOFTOP - CONTINUOUS

Koa watches from a crumbling church roof. Eyes narrowed.

The wagons. The tents. The children laughing.

KOA (TO HIMSELF)
You never gave them time to forget, did you?

He pulls his hood lower and disappears down the other side of the roof.

EXT. CARNIVAL GROUNDS - LATER

The striped tents are nearly raised. Straps snap taut. Ferris wheel gears grind backwards into place.

A small STAGE is being built, shabby velvet curtains, old footlights.

A crooked sign hangs: “THE BOOK OF ENDLESS STORIES CARNIVAL - ONE NIGHT ONLY”.

FADE OUT.

INT. DERELICT HOUSE - EDGE OF TOWN - DUSK

The house leans into the wind like it’s trying to disappear. Shutters clatter loose. The porch has forgotten how to hold weight. Inside: rot, dust, and something older than both.

A ROTTING MIRROR stands cracked in the middle of the room. Its glass twitches, trying to hold still. Shadows flit behind it that aren’t in the room.

GIDEON MARR (60s), bone-thin, burning with fever, stares into the mirror. His breath fogs the glass. It does not fog back.

GIDEON
(to the mirror)
You feel it, don’t you?

The mirror ripples. Then clears. A REFLECTION appears—not of the room, but a rooftop across town.

KOA MAHELONA (20s), lean muscle and sealed focus, stands at the edge of town. Frayed coat to the wind. Watching.

Gideon tenses. Something tightens in his hand—

A THIN BLADE of old steel.

GIDEON (CONT’D)
(beat)
You never were done with it, were you?

He places the blade on the floor. Slides it toward the mirror.

The mirror doesn’t react. But the SATCHEL by his foot does. It jerks. Whines. Like a dog that smells thunder.

Gideon opens it. Slowly. Inside:

A SMALL BOOK, bound in flesh-toned cloth. Breathing. Shivering.

He doesn't touch it. Not yet. Instead, he pulls out a stack of drawings, rendered in ink and something darker.

Ava, holding a dandelion. Not smiling. Leo, covered in ash, eyes wrong. Carter, lit by fire.

He flips to the last page.

Koa. Younger. Wounded. Not yet broken.

GIDEON (CONT'D)
(quietly)
You all came back. Even him.

A WIND rises—but only inside. The pages SCATTER. Swirl around him.

He finally opens the Book.

It FLARES. Symbols crawl up the inside spine. They do not stay in place.

GIDEON (CONT'D)
(to the Book)
Don't pretend to sleep.

He pricks his thumb. Blood wells. Drips onto the page.

The Book drinks. Devours.

GIDEON (CONT'D)
(write-whispers)
Bring them in.

A CRACK runs through the floorboards. Ink seeps up from the seams.

IN THE MIRROR: Koa turns slightly. As if he felt something. He pulls out a MATCHBOX from his coat, old, dented. He flicks it open. Inside: one match remains, alongside a piece of string. Burnt at both ends.

KOA
(eyes swelling)
You said I'd never carry fire again.

Gideon watches the mirror, breathless.

GIDEON
Say no, Koa. I need you to say no.

The mirror goes DARK as the Book closes on its own.

GIDEON (CONT'D)
(softly)
Not again.

He clutches the satchel. It shakes. Something inside begins to hum.

CHILD (V.O.)
If the story calls your name, don't answer.

The mirror shows one last flicker—

Koa walking away, disappears into the dark.

CUT TO:

INT. LIVING ROOM - SAME TIME

Carter kneels by the old side table. Opens the drawer. Hesitates.

He pulls out the lockbox. Sits on the rug, cross-legged like a kid who's about to do something he knows he shouldn't.

Opens it.

The contents unchanged: the faded ticket. The rings. The photo. The bills.

Carter picks up the ticket. "GIDEON'S CARNIVAL OF ENDINGS & WONDERS."

He flips it over. A number is scrawled there. Unfamiliar.

AVA (O.S.)
Dinner's almost ready.

Carter blinks. Doesn't move. His thumb brushes the paper's edge as if trying to find an answer.

AVA (O.S.) (CONT'D)
You're gonna talk to him, right?
He's just a kid, Car.

CARTER
I know.

INT. DINING ROOM – NIGHT

Plates are set. Dinner cooling. Ava stands at the window, staring out into the dark.

Carter paces, anxious.

AVA
You could've told him why. Even a little.

CARTER
Would it matter? He'd still want to go.

AVA
And now?

A silence.

AVA (CONT'D)
Car?

CARTER
I'll talk to him. After we eat.

She watches him, unsure.

INT. HALLWAY – MOMENTS LATER

Ava climbs the stairs, rubbing her arms. A wind moans outside.

She reaches Leo's door. Knocks.

AVA
Leo?

Nothing.

She opens the door slowly.

INT. LEO'S ROOM – CONTINUOUS

Window open. Curtain billowing. Shoes gone.

On the bed: the carnival flyer.

One word scrawled across the bottom: SORRY.

Ava freezes. For a second, she forgets to breathe.

AVA
(small)
No, no, no...

She turns, sprints to the stairs—

INT. ENTRYWAY - MOMENTS LATER

Carter's halfway to the dining room when she grabs his arm.

AVA
He's not here. He's gone.

CARTER
What?

She shoves the flyer at him. He reads it.

CARTER (CONT'D)
No. No, no—

His voice cracks. He turns, grabs his coat.

AVA
Where would he even—

CARTER
The carnival.

EXT. HOUSE - NIGHT

They burst out the front door. Carter nearly trips on the steps.

Ava spins in a slow circle, desperate, scanning the empty street.

CARTER
Leo!

Sounds of distant calliope music winds through the streets. The Carnival has begun.

CUT TO:

EXT. CARNIVAL GROUNDS - SUNSET

The wind carries distant laughter, but it feels... hollow. A calliope churns a fractured melody as lights spin too fast, too bright.

A TEENAGE CARNIVAL WORKER (19), face painted in silver stars, eyes too old for his age, works the ticket booth.

LEO (13), out of breath, rolls up on a bike. Hoodie half-zipped. Shoes untied. Fear and wonder battle in his chest.

He drops the kickstand. Looks up.

Before him, the CARNIVAL unfurls, sprawling, alive, and too perfect. Not a smudge on the striped tents. Not a wire out of place.

Leo fishes into his pocket. Pulls out crumpled bills. Holds them out.

The WORKER studies him.

WORKER
You came alone?

Leo hesitates.

LEO
Not really.

The Worker doesn't ask what he means. Just tears a ticket. Hands it over. Their fingers touch.

Leo flinches, a strange static spark.

WORKER
Welcome back.

Leo smiles as the sound and color pull him forward.

The Worker watches him go. Something pained in his expression.

Behind him, in shadow: GIDEON.

GIDEON
The first one's arrived. Make sure the tent's open.

The Worker nods. Swallows hard.

CUT TO:

INT. CARTER'S CAR - NIGHT - MOVING

Carter grips the wheel. Ava stares out the window, chewing her sleeve.

AVA
You think he'd really go alone?

CARTER
I think I should've stopped him this morning.

AVA
That's not an answer.

The town blurs by. Lights flicker. Something in the night feels off, like a page turned wrong.

They pull up to the edge of the CARNIVAL.

EXT. CARNIVAL PARKING - NIGHT

Families stream past in laughter, balloons and glitter everywhere.

Carter and Ava jump out. Rush toward the gate.

A NEIGHBORHOOD MOM passes with two young kids.

CARTER
Sorry, excuse me, have you seen this boy?

He holds up Leo's school photo on his phone.

She squints.

MOM
Yeah... think he went in earlier. Looked excited. Sweet kid.

Carter's jaw tightens. Ava turns, scanning the crowd.

INT. CARNIVAL GROUNDS - NIGHT

Leo weaves through the crowd. Drawn forward.

Something ancient calls to him through the noise.

Ahead, a tent. Smaller than the rest. Tucked away. Its fabric darker. Stars stitched in threads that seem to shift.

On the flap: a symbol, a feather inside a circle of ink. A sign reads: "DO NOT ENTER."

Leo stops. The feather in his bracelet glows faintly.

He steps closer.

The tent flap curls open on its own.

INT. BOOK TENT - CONTINUOUS

The inside is vast emptiness, except for a PEDESTAL IN THE CENTER.

Atop it: THE BOOK.

Bound in ancient leather. Covered in shifting inscriptions. Locked with no lock. Lit by a single beam of moonlight, though there’s no hole above.

Leo steps into the tent slowly. His breath visible in the air.

LEO
(softly)
What is this place...

He approaches the Book.

It HUMS. The room darkens. Only him and it.

He reaches out and the feather flares.

The book opens on its own. Pages turn. Then stop. A BLANK PAGE.

A WHISPER, HISSING HIS NAME: LEO LONDON...

Leo’s hand rises, he’s not in control. His palm presses to the page.

The INK LIFTS OFF THE PAGE to meet him.

Suddenly... a SURGE OF BRIGHT LIGHT.

The entire tent pulses.

FROM FAR AWAY:

INT. SOMEWHERE DEEPER - UNKNOWN REALM

The EXECUTIONER stands in a hall of endless, distorted mirrors, her stitched armor catching glints of fractured reflection. Her head tilts.

A faint, almost inaudible WHISPER on the air, like a page being turned in reverse.

She blinks. Her eyes flare. She knows.

BACK TO:

EXT. CARNIVAL GROUNDS - MOMENTS LATER

Carter and Ava see the shimmer above the tent.

AVA
There.

They run.

EXT. BOOK TENT - CONTINUOUS

They reach the tent. It's flap still open.

Ava spots LEO'S BACKPACK on the ground near the pedestal.

They look at each other.

CARTER
Leo?

No answer.

INT. BOOK TENT - CONTINUOUS

They step inside, cautious.

The tent is colder now. Hushed. The Book closed. Waiting.

AVA
This feels...

She touches the pedestal.

AVA (CONT'D)
Familiar.

Carter kneels by the backpack. The zipper ripped. Inside, Leo's phone. Still warm. Sees something tucked in a side pocket: A photo, of all three of them. Faded. The corner burned.

The Book OPENS AGAIN. Pages flutter. Wind kicks up.

Ava stares at the photo. Her hand tightens around Carter's.

The BOOK GLOWS.

Carter looks at the pedestal. At the photo.

Then, the wind rips it from his fingers. THE PHOTO CATCHES FIRE MID-AIR.

They gasp. The Book SURGES WITH LIGHT.

THE LIGHT EXPLODES —

FADE TO WHITE.

EXT. THE STRANGE SHORE — UNKNOWN TIME

A sharp GASP of breath.

Leo lies on the wet sand, curled in on himself, shaking. The wind brushes over his face like a breath from something old.

He opens his eyes.

The sky above him glows lavender and green. Clouds drift backward. The sun is a pale thread pulling slowly across the horizon.

He sits up, soaked, barefoot, hoodie clinging to him.

Behind him, an ocean, completely still. Not a wave, not a sound. Glass flat.

Before him, a field of tall white grass, humming softly.

Not wind. The grass is humming.

LEO
(calling out)
Ava... Carter... hello...

He stands.

Every step he takes sends ripples of color beneath his feet, as if the soil remembers dreams.

LEO (CONT'D)
(quietly)
This... isn't real.

Far off: Ruins. Stone arches cracked in half. Floating pieces suspended mid-collapse. Symbols flickering across them like forgotten languages.

Leo walks forward, drawn.

He passes a tree where the bark peels like pages. Each strip covered in UNFAMILIAR handwriting.

His breathing tightens.

INT. SMALL CLEARING – MOMENTS LATER

Leo steps into a clearing. The hum stops.

A single swing set stands in the center. Rusted chains. Faded blue paint.

He walks toward it. Something recognized.

He reaches out, touches the seat.

FLASH MEMORY:

A GIRL, maybe Ava, pushing him. Laughter. The smell of spring. The sun in the right color.

BACK TO:

Leo jerks his hand back.

LEO
That never happened.

Behind him, the grass parts.

A FIGURE steps through.

Tall. Cloaked. Face hidden beneath a soft veil of moths. It doesn’t speak, just gestures.

In its hands, an open sketchbook.

It flips a page.

A drawing appears: Leo. Standing exactly where he is, looking at the figure.

Then, another drawing: Leo, taking the figure’s hand.

LEO (CONT’D)
What is this place?

No answer.

The figure flips again. Now Leo is falling into a crack in the sky. The drawing... moves, a looped nightmare.

Leo takes a step back.

The swing creaks.

The air goes cold.

He turns, but the swing is gone. The clearing is shifting.

The ocean now closer than it should be. Waves rise, flowing upward into the sky.

The figure lowers the sketchbook. Reaches out.

LEO (CONT'D)
Are you going to help me?

The figure tilts its head.

FIGURE
(whispers)
Every story needs a beginning.

The moths scatter, revealing a face ALMOST LIKE LEO'S. Not quite. Older. Hollow-eyed.

Leo GASPS, but it's too late.

The ground splits beneath him.

He falls, screaming, into a ribbon of light.

CUT TO:

EXT. GUTTERGLASS MINES - NIGHT

BLACK.

A wet gasp. Then... pain.

Ava slams into frame from above, hitting jagged metal shale. The ground is made of rusted script fractured letters welded into terrain.

She coughs. Ink spills from her mouth.

Everything around her is clanging, hollow, dying.

AVA
(groaning)
Carter...?

She tries to stand, a sharp cry. Her arm is cut. Deep.

A faint, luminous fog clings to the ground, not mist, but fine metallic dust. It coils around her limbs, slow and strange.

The wind here is not wind, it’s the sound of distant grinding. Chains, maybe. Or gears. Or bones.

She stumbles forward.

Then... something moves.

A CREATURE crawls from the wreckage nearby, part flesh, part copper. Moth-like wings, torn and laced with script. Its chest glows like coal.

It sees her.

CREATURE
(whisper — distorted)
Ava.

She freezes.

The creature coughs. Its body flickers.

CREATURE (CONT’D)
Too late. You shouldn't... The mine remembers.

It reaches toward her, not hostile. Begging.

AVA
Who are you?

CREATURE
You were... one of the inkbound.

Its eyes burn out. Its wings crumble. The body folds inward vanishing in a blink of negative light.

Silence.

Then a thunderous, low moan echoes from deep below.

The earth beneath Ava trembles.

Chains rattle far in the distance.

AVA
(to herself, shaken)
What is this place?

She turns, sees a distant spire of glass and bone, flickering with symbols.

Behind her, something watches from the dark.

CUT TO:

INT. THE FORGOTTEN LIBRARY - UNKNOWN TIME

BLACKNESS.

Then, light flickers.

A faint, golden shimmer pulses through dust.

Carter gasps and jerks upright, coughing ink. His eyes adjust slowly. Around him—A LIBRARY WITHOUT END.

A cathedral of shelves, each towering higher than the next, vanishing into dark rafters.

Books float. Some hover mid-air, pages open. Others crumble to ash with no sound. The floor is stone—cracked, warped, as if the building is breathing beneath him.

CARTER
(softly)
Where the hell...

He stands. Wobbly. Ink drips from his fingers. His jacket is torn. One shoe missing.

CARTER (CONT'D)
(calling out)
Ava... where are you?

On a pillar near him, words appear. Not etched. Written. Ink forming sentences on aged stone.

PILLAR
(text)
Those who enter forget the ending.
Those who stay forget the
beginning.

Carter backs away from it.

CARTER
Nope. No thanks.

As he turns, his foot lands on a pressure plate. A GROANING SOUND fills the space, like hundreds of voices whispering at once.

A BOOK floats toward him.

Small. Leatherbound. Humming.

It opens in front of him.

Carter hesitates. Then steps closer.

Words appear across the page, written in real time.

BOOK
(text)
The boy forgot the first time he left her. He would forget again.

CARTER
What is this?

The pages flip. Faster. Images now. Sketches:

- A GIRL with dark curls.

- A FIELD of broken clocks.

- A CARNIVAL on fire.

Carter’s hands shake. He touches the edge of the page, flinches. A memory tries to claw its way out. But it’s not whole. Not his.

CARTER (CONT’D)
That’s not... me. Is it?

WHISPERS flood the room. Every book around him begins to stir. Shelves rattle.

The book in front of him now glows brighter. Too bright.

He slams it shut.

Everything stops.

Except one sound.

From the far end of the library, a slow, deliberate tapping. Like nails on wood.

Carter turns.

Silhouetted by broken light, a figure.

Tall. Hooded. Carrying something long wrapped in fabric.

It lifts its head. No face. Just stitched parchment.

CARTER STUMBLES BACK.

The BOOK trembles in his hand.

FIGURE
You are late to your chapter.

CUT TO:

EXT. CARNIVAL GROUNDS - NIGHT

A gust of wind stirs confetti along the gravel path.

From the edge of the trees, a FIGURE. Koa emerges, long coat, boots worn to the sole, a half-burned cigarette behind one ear.

He walks slowly, as the Carnival music rises warbled.

Performers drift across the grounds. Painted faces. Hollow eyes. One stops sweeping dirt from a wagon step. Nods to Koa.

PERFORMER
(quiet)
It’s started again.

Koa doesn’t answer. He just looks up toward the flicker of static above the carnival’s main arch. Neon twists into unreadable script, then resets.

He walks through it like a ghost. Hood up. Eyes forward.

EXT. CARNIVAL GROUNDS - CONTINUOUS

The wind presses low. Lanterns hiss. Shadows coil between the tents.

Koa moves, silent and watchful.

Everything is off. Music stutters, skipping like a broken record.

He reaches the edge of the Book Tent.

Koa lays a hand against the fabric. It pulses. Alive. A beat older than memory.

He closes his eyes.

KOA
Not yet.

The fabric tightens beneath his palm, almost rejecting him. Or remembering him.

Gideon emerges from the shadows. Staggered. Pale. His hands shake like he's been holding something heavy too long.

GIDEON
You're not supposed to be here.

Koa studies him. The silence between them is jagged.

KOA
Neither were you.

Gideon flinches. Koa steps forward. Close enough to see the ink at Gideon's fingertips.

KOA (CONT'D)
You promised. No more doors. No more names.

GIDEON
I didn't choose them.

KOA
But you watched them go.

Gideon's eyes flicker. His mouth twists into something like guilt, then past it.

GIDEON
The Book wanted them. It opened on its own.

KOA
So you let it.

GIDEON
What do you want from me?
(his voice cracking)
I'm trying to bring them back.

KOA
You left them.

GIDEON
(exploding)
I ran because I had no choice. You think I wanted to crawl out of that place without them? Without my wife—

KOA
You sent me in after her. And your daughter. Alone.

GIDEON
You volunteered.

KOA
I was seventeen.
(beat)
And you left me, too.

The words land hard. Gideon looks away. Can't hold them.

KOA (CONT'D)
I nearly died in there. For you.
For the ending you wanted.

GIDEON
(quiet)
I wanted an ending where you
weren't a coward.

The silence between them threatens to rupture. Koa steps closer. Inches.

KOA
You wanted someone else to blame.

Gideon grabs Koa's jacket, fists shaking.

GIDEON
You don't understand. I hear her.
Anna. Sometimes when I sleep. When
I bleed.
(his voice breaks)
The Book still has her. I feel it.

KOA
That's not love. That's obsession.

Gideon loosens his grip. His hand drops, limp.

GIDEON
You think you're better than me?

KOA
No. I just stopped lying to myself.

Gideon looks toward the Book Tent.

GIDEON
It's not too late. You could go
back.
(softer)
You're still the only one it hasn't
taken.

Koa doesn’t move.

KOA
Then I’ll keep it that way.

He turns. Walks past Gideon.

GIDEON (O.S.)
We’ll be gone come morning.

Koa pauses.

Behind him, a whisper. Barely audible. A girl’s voice:

MIREN (V.O.)
Don’t let him feed the pages.

Koa freezes. His hand clutches his wrist where an old scar flares dimly, like a coal remembering fire.

He doesn’t turn.

He just walks.

CUT TO:

EXT. EMBERGLOW FOREST - NIGHT

Silent. Choked with ash and ink.

Leo lies curled in the scorched underbrush. Breathing, barely.

His eyes flutter open, the forest above him burns blue. Ink drips from gnarled branches like molten wax. Thread-thin vines twitch, alive with whispers.

The feather necklace around his neck pulses. Once. Twice. Then brands itself into his skin with a quiet, searing burn.

Leo gasps. Sits up. Disoriented.

Behind his eyes, memory fractures: — flashes of Carter, Ava — his mother’s voice — a door slamming — gone. Replaced by smoke and static.

He grips his head, slowly standing.

Nearby, movement. A GIRL MADE OF THREAD watches from between two mirror-polished trees. No eyes. Just quiet knowing. Then, gone.

Leo staggers forward, barefoot. Leaves made of paper crumble beneath him. Every breath staggered.

He stumbles upon: A TREE. Its branches are made of warped books, stitched spines, torn covers. Pages flutter like dead birds.

Leo climbs.

A step. Then another. Reaching for something, anything.

One book opens.

INT. PAGE (FANTASY FLASH) - BRIEF VISION

A boy not-him but-almost, drowning in a house made of mirrors.

BACK TO:

EXT. EMBERGLOW FOREST - CONTINUOUS

The branch SNAPS.

Leo tumbles hard, hits the forest floor. The tree SHRIEKS as if alive.

Then silence, until—

WHISPERS surround him. Something moves through the trees. Not walking. Gliding.

A FACELESS CREATURE slithers from shadow. Ink pours from its hollow shoulders. Its voice is every bedtime story turned nightmare:

FACELESS CREATURE
You should not exist.

Leo runs.

Branches claw. Roots grasp. The forest HUNTS.

He trips, slams hard, the feather burning now like a brand.

Just before the creature reaches him—

A HAND.

Thread-woven. Gentle. Pulls him back into a shallow hollow beneath the roots.

The GIRL. Closer now. Still eyeless. Still silent.

She leans in.

GIRL OF THREAD
(whispers)
Never speak your name aloud.

Then, softer, non threatening, protective:

GIRL OF THREAD (CONT'D)
Come. She's waiting.

Leo nods, trembling. Now clutching the feather necklace, fully activated with a slight glow. He follows her deeper into the ink-lit woods.

A feather trail flickers in their wake.

CUT TO:

EXT. EMBERGLOW FOREST - PRE-DAWN

Distant screech of the faceless thing.

The forest tightens behind them. As if trying to forget he was ever there.

CUT TO:

EXT. GUTTERGLASS MINES - DAWN

An ocean of rusted iron and ink-slick stone. Caverns curl like broken ribs beneath a bruised sky.

The mine exhales, a slow rhythmic, metallic groan.

Ava lies on her side, coughing black flecks. Her hands tremble. Her skin is streaked with soot and memory she doesn't recognize.

Beside her, a SMALL CREATURE, torn-winged, leaking dark ichor, twitches in pain. Its ribs pulse like cracked glass.

She reaches for it, gently lifts it.

AVA
I won't leave you.

The creature warms faintly in her arms. A scar flickers beneath her sleeve.

A WHISPER snakes through the stone.

WHISPER (V.O.)
Ava London... Ava London...

She freezes.

WHISPER (V.O.)
Silent Guardian. Protector of the Hollow.

Her grip tightens. The scar burns brighter.

AVA
No.

The whisper wavers. The mine breathes again. She pushes forward.

INT. GUTTERGLASS MINES - MORNING

Corridors shift. Metal groans and rearranges. Walls recede. A path forms, narrow, uncertain.

A glowing ARCHWAY rises ahead, etched with rusted words: “ALL WHO GUARD MUST NOT SPEAK.”

Ava approaches, but the floor beneath her SPLITS. Chains SNAP up from the ground, coil around her arms. A BRANDING SIGIL carves toward her skin a molten word forming: “SILENT GUARDIAN.”

AVA
NO—

AVA (CONT’D)
(screaming)
I SAID NO!

Her scream ECHOES, shatters the silence like brittle iron.

The brand falters. A CRACK ripples through the mine floor beneath her feet. Walls SHRIEK. A new tunnel TEARS open behind her.

INT. GUTTERGLASS MINES - DUSK

Everything is colder. The mine pulses slower. Faint embers drift like dying fireflies.

Ava limps down the tunnel, the creature cradled close. It barely breathes. She stops beneath a shard-ribbed overhang.

A sketchbook dangles from twisted roots overhead.

Her fingers brush it. Its leather is warm. Alive.

She opens it. The pages are blank. Then one curls and shifts, revealing a half-formed sketch... of Leo.

Behind her, a low CLICKING.

She turns.

A MONSTROUS SILHOUETTE.

Spindled limbs. Ink-drenched hide. Rows of TEETH STITCHED SHUT.

The creature in her arms SHUDDERS and BURSTS with light.

In one jagged breath, it begins to CHANGE.

Wings unfurl, black-glass and burning. Horns twist upward. Its limbs reshape—

It stands between her and the monster, GROWLING.

AVA
(soft)
You're real.

The monster tenses... lunges—

AVA (CONT'D)
Your name is BRIM.

A SHOCKWAVE detonates from the creature's chest.

The monster SHRIEKS, reeling... the world QUAKES.

Her scar BURNS. Her voice locks the name into the stone.

WHISPER (V.O.)
To name is to anchor.

Brim lands beside her. Wounded but standing. One eye glowing.

It leans close. Whispers in a tongue she doesn't know and yet understands.

BRIM (V.O.)
The boy with the ink-feather lives.

A beat. Ava's eyes widen.

BRIM (V.O.)
He travels east. Emberglow. You must not arrive alone.

She looks down at her sketchbook.

A new page unfolds. A symbol etches itself across the parchment: “ONLY DRAW WHAT YOU ACCEPT. EVERY IMAGE HAS A PRICE.”

Ava holds the sketchbook tight to her chest.

She steps toward the new tunnel Brim uncovered the light ahead dimming to crimson.

Then... sketches a quick symbol. A compass. The lines shimmer and point her east.

AVA
I’m coming, Leo.

She walks into the dark, Brim at her side.

CUT TO:

INT. FORGOTTEN LIBRARY - DUSK

Silence. Then a breath. A twitch.

Carter blinks awake beneath the high, blackened spires. The Library around him is darker now, more brittle. Like a memory left out in the rain.

He’s on the floor beside a stone dais. Books lie scattered, some torn open, others still whispering in languages not meant for the living.

CARTER
(sotto)
Still here.

The book in his hands, the one that tried to name him, hums again. Gently.

He starts to open it.

A VOICE.

CHILD OF INK (O.S.)
That one’s yours.

Carter jerks his head up. The CHILD OF INK stands at the far end of the dais, barefoot on warped wood, tilting its head like a broken marionette.

CHILD OF INK (CONT'D)
Wants to be read.

CARTER
Yeah. Not happening.

CHILD OF INK
Why not?

CARTER
Because I know what happens next.

CHILD OF INK
Do you?

Carter frowns. He stands slowly, keeping the book closed.

CHILD OF INK (CONT'D)
This place likes to keep things.
Names. Faces. Pieces of yourself.
But not all at once.

The air warps. A flicker of movement behind Carter.

He turns. Nothing there. Turns back —

The FACELESS FIGURE now stands beside the Child of Ink. Identical height. Identical stillness. Only the stitched parchment mask separates them.

FACELESS FIGURE
You are late to your chapter.

CARTER
(deep breath)
Not this again—

CHILD OF INK
(singsong)
You forgot her name.

Carter freezes.

CARTER
What?

CHILD OF INK
You forgot the girl who never let
go. Even when you did.

FLASH: a sliver of memory. A girl in a sunlit field. Laughing. A locket. Her hand slipping from his—

Carter flinches like he's been stabbed.

FACELESS FIGURE
Read.

The book in Carter's hands TWITCHES. Opens itself.

Words etch across the page, ALIVE IN REAL TIME:

BOOK (TEXT)
The boy had no choice. He left her behind. She smiled anyway. That was the last time he saw her—

Carter SLAMS it shut.

The Library SHUDDERS. Lights flicker. Books SCREAM.

CARTER
NO!

FACELESS FIGURE
You cannot outrun an ending.

CARTER
Watch me.

WHISPERS swell from the walls. Books begin to spin, hover, pages flaring with light. Two of them SHATTER against each other, fusing into a single inkstorm.

Carter turns to run, but stops.

A mirror of swirling ink rises before him. Floating midair.

Within it, flashes:

- AVA, in the mines. Her hand on a creature's chest.

- LEO, standing at the edge of something vast, something broken.

- Their eyes. Searching. Empty.

The images GLITCH, overlaid with Carter's own face. Then wiped away in a swipe of ink.

CHILD OF INK
They are stories. But not finished.
Not yet.

CARTER
Where?

CHILD OF INK
(quietly)
You'll need to find the spine.

CARTER
What does that mean—

A LOW CREAK runs through the shelves.

Books SHIFT. A towering column of SPINES UNFUSES, dropping in a slow, shuddering collapse.

Carter throws an arm up as a rain of books thuds around him... and then stops.

Left behind on the stone is a NARROW SHAFT: A staff made from fused book-spines and splintered wood, its length wrapped in frayed binding.

Carter stares at it.

CHILD OF INK
(not quite smiling)
Every story needs a spine.

He hesitates. Then reaches down, fingers closing around it. As he does, a FEATHERED MARK on his chest gives a faint answering pulse beneath his shirt.

The Child of Ink just smiles.

CHILD OF INK (CONT'D)
But first—
(beat)
Don't ever read your own ending.

FACELESS FIGURE
Unless you're ready to write it.

Suddenly.. Carter clutches his chest. A FEATHERED MARK glows beneath his shirt. Faint. Fading in and out like breath.

The Book in his hand now trembles. Begins to open again.

On the page: A new sentence forms—

BOOK (TEXT)
She dies believing he will come back—

Carter's fingers tremble. His eyes glaze.

FLASH: HER FACE AGAIN. The girl from before. She’s older now. Eyes full of tears. Holding something, a piece of paper. Folded.

Carter SCREAMS—

And HURLS the book into the ink-mirror.

It vanishes. So does the mirror.

Silence.

He stands. Alone again. Sweating. Breathing hard.

CHILD OF INK
(sincerely)
They’re waiting. But they won’t remember you... unless you make them.

CARTER
I will.

The Child nods.

From behind a shelf, a trail of golden ink appears, leading forward.

Carter steps into it. And disappears.

CUT TO:

EXT. CARNIVAL TENT - LATE NIGHT

Wind cuts through the empty tents. Banners hang limp. The Carnival is hollow now. Waiting.

INT. GIDEON'S TRAILER - SAME

Darkness presses in. Dim lantern light flickers over peeling walls. The sink is full of ink.

Gideon hunched over it. Shirt soaked. Arms trembling. He coughs. Hard. Violent.

Black ink sprays the mirror.

GIDEON
(hoarse)
No... not yet...

He claws open a drawer. Hands shaking. Pulls out a LOCKET, tarnished gold.

Inside: A woman's face. Young. Soft-eyed. Smiling.

He touches it like a wound.

GIDEON (CONT'D)
Anna...

The locket pulses faintly.

And the mirror SPEAKS.

BOOK (V.O.)
(but it's Anna's voice)
You promised me a way back.

Gideon staggers. Grabs the edge of the sink.

GIDEON
This isn't you.

BOOK (V.O.)
Isn't it?

In the mirror, her reflection. The woman from the locket. Crying ink.

BOOK (V.O.)
You ran.

The mirror fractures. Gideon FALLS BACK, hitting the wall hard.

Silence.

Then, a rustle of parchment. A shifting of shadow.

The tent walls BREATHE. Ink seeps through the seams.

INT. THE CARNIVAL - ELSEWHERE - SAME

Tents flutter. The entire fairground seems to TILT. Lanterns burn blue.

INT. GIDEON'S TRAILER - CONTINUOUS

Gideon claws his way to his feet.

His eyes are bleeding ink. He fumbles for a coat. For breath. For control.

GIDEON
One more. Just one more night.

Behind him — a tall silhouette unfurls from shadow.

THE EXECUTIONER.

Her armor stitched from pages. A blade of feathered steel at her side. Her face — paper-white beneath a cracked mask. The ink that runs down her arms hums with command.

GIDEON (CONT'D)
(faltering)
Anna?

She says nothing. But the locket at his neck BURNS.

EXECUTIONER
You stalled the ending.

GIDEON
They weren't ready—

EXECUTIONER
They must return.

He stares at her. At what she's become. His voice breaks.

GIDEON
You don't have to do this. If there's anything left—

She steps forward. The Book's voice rides hers.

BOOK / EXECUTIONER
Those who escape must one day return... or the story collapses.

The ground TREMBLES.

Somewhere in the Book-world, a vault CRACKS open. Koa feels this.

EXECUTIONER
Take another child. Keep the gate open.

Gideon's hand clenches around the locket. Blood seeps through his palm.

GIDEON
(whispers)
Forgive me.

She fades. Into ink. Into parchment. Gone.

Gideon stands alone.

The Carnival lights FLICKER BACK TO LIFE.

He wipes his mouth. Puts on the mask. Steps out into the night.

Behind him, the cracked mirror still whispers.

BOOK (V.O.)
Your chapter is almost over.

CUT TO:

EXT. CARNIVAL FIELD - PRE-DAWN

Blue tinged mist bleeds across the grass. The Carnival stands. Silent. Hollow. Wrong.

Koa waits at the treeline. Breath sharp in the cold. Watching.

KOA
(under breath)
You said one night.

He steps forward. Slow. Every footfall carries memory. Guilt. Resolve.

INT. CARNIVAL - TUNNEL OF STORIES - CONTINUOUS

The archway yawns open, dripping ink from its painted mouth.

A TEEN GIRL, maybe 15, one of the Carnival’s temp hires, stands just outside. Eyes wide. Backpack clutched.

Behind her, GIDEON.

GIDEON
You like stories, don’t you?

She nods, hesitant.

GIDEON (CONT’D)
This one’s about a girl who got to be anything she wanted.

KOA (O.S.)
That’s not how it ends.

Gideon freezes. Turns.

Koa steps through the mist. A ghost from a broken chapter.

KOA (CONT’D)
She forgets her name. Her face. Screams when the Book edits too deep.

The girl looks between them. Frozen.

GIDEON
This isn’t your business anymore.

KOA
It never stopped being mine.

Gideon’s hand brushes the LOCKET under his coat. The metal hums.

GIDEON
She’s a story waiting to be told. Better I guide her than let the Book choose.

KOA
You’re not guiding anyone. You’re feeding it.

The girl edges back. Uncertain. Then—

KOA (CONT’D)
Go home. Don’t look back.

She hesitates. Breath catches.

And runs. Into the fog. Gone.

Silence falls. Gideon watches her vanish.

GIDEON
I needed one more.

KOA
Then take me.

Gideon blinks. That wound in him flares.

GIDEON
You don’t know what you’re asking.

KOA
I do.
(beat)
Tell the Book, the gate stays open for me.

Gideon looks down. Ink drips from his fingers.

GIDEON
Why would you go back?

Koa slightly flintches. He can’t say her name. Not yet.

KOA
Because someone’s still in there.

A beat. The LOCKET flickers with light.

Gideon lifts his gaze. He knows who.

GIDEON
You won’t survive it.

KOA
Maybe not. But she might.

A long silence, then, Gideon nods. Not forgiveness. Not surrender. Something heavier.

He pulls a TATTERED PAGE from his coat. It glows faintly. Whispers.

GIDEON
Say your name before you forget it.

KOA
Koa Mahelona.

He takes the page.

The Carnival shudders. The lights dim. The world narrows.

Koa closes his eyes.

A ripple cuts through the air, a narrative seam. A low tremor, like the turning of a colossal page.

The page ignites. Blue fire consumes him. Gone.

INT. GIDEON’S TRAILER - MOMENTS LATER

Gideon collapses at the sink. Ink spilling from his mouth. Eyes empty.

The LOCKET swings open, Anna's face staring back.

A whisper curls in the air. Just under breath.

GIDEON
Anna...

CUT TO:

INT. THE BOOK - UNKNOWN CHAPTER - DARKNESS

A faint echo of a feather-knife. A tremor.

Far away, a girl in a stitched mask turns her head.

CUT TO:

EXT. CHAPTER WILDS - NIGHT

Shredded parchment drifts like ash. Twisted trees — their bark etched with half-erased names — lean inward as if listening. The wind carries whispers, none of them kind.

Carter stumbles through the underbrush of a world fraying at the edges, using the SPINE STAFF as much for balance as defense. His clothes are torn. His knuckles still bloodied. The golden ink trail is long gone.

His breath fogs. He's shivering.

CARTER
Ava... Leo...

No answer.

Every shadow is a shape. Every silence is too loud. Above him, a piece of sky peels open — revealing not stars, but words in dead languages blinking across the firmament like constellations no one remembers.

A sound behind him.

He turns.

Something just out of view — pale limbs retreating behind a dead tree. Long. Too long. Not human.

He picks up speed. Doesn't run. Not yet. The staff scrapes rock and root as he moves.

INT. STONE NARROWS - LATER

Carter pushes through a break in the rocks — deeper into what feels like the Book's understructure. The air grows thick. Electric. Like breathing through paper soaked in ink.

He emerges onto a ledge.

Below, THE SPINE. An ancient corridor carved into the rootwork of this world.

A living spinewire and ink-threaded memory vines, coiling like the ruins of language long buried. Book fragments float midair, turning slowly, humming.

He descends.

INT. THE SPINE - MOMENTS LATER

It's cold. Still. Too still.

As Carter moves forward, pages unfurl from the walls. Names etched into their centers, some crossed out, others glowing faintly.

He stops. One of them pulses.

PAGE (TEXT)
Ava Brighton.

His breath catches.

CARTER
I'm close.

He takes another step, SPINE STAFF tapping against the stone-

CRACK.

Something fast and heavy SLAMS into him from the side.

He hits the ground HARD, rolls, scrambles, the SPINE STAFF skids out of his hand, CLATTERING across the floor.

Koa, wild-eyed, bruised, feral, pins him down.

KOA
Who sent you?

CARTER
Let go!

KOA
Answer me!

Carter knees him. Koa grunts, loses balance, Carter shoves him off, scrambling toward the fallen staff.

Both roll to their feet. Face off.

Carter SNATCHES up the SPINE STAFF and swings in a wild arc.

Koa steps inside it, grabs the shaft, TWISTS. The staff RIPS out of Carter's hands. In one fluid motion, Koa reverses it and DRIVES him back against the wall, wood across his chest.

CARTER
I don't know who you are.

A BLADE now at his throat as Koa pins him.

KOA
Then you're already dead.

He lunges.

Carter ducks, slams his shoulder into Koa's ribs. They crash against the memory vines. One of them WRITHES and cuts Carter's forearm.

Blood. Real. He stares, gasping.

Koa hesitates. Sees something.

A MARK beneath Carter's shirt. Faint. Feathered.

KOA (CONT'D)
You came through.

CARTER
I'm looking for my sister. And my brother.

Koa lowers his blade. But only just.

KOA
There's someone still in here. Her name's Miren.
(beat)
If she found them... maybe she'll find you.

CARTER
That's not enough.

KOA
It’s all we’ve got.

Behind them, a rustle.

Both freeze.

Across the corridor, something crawls along the ceiling.

LIMBLESS. SILENT. Its mouth stitched shut. Its skin made of folded parchment and snapped quills.

It doesn’t see them.

Yet.

Koa pulls Carter into the shadows.

KOA (CONT’D)
(quietly)
Help me help you.
(a beat)
It’s the only way we survive.

Koa starts to move. On his way past, he SNAGS the SPINE STAFF from where it fell and shoves it into Carter’s hands.

KOA (CONT’D)
(grim)
If you’re going to carry it, stop swinging it like a club.

Carter grips it tighter. Doesn’t argue.

Off Carter, panting, heart racing —

FADE OUT.

EXT. THE THREADWARREN PATHWAYS - LATER

Carter and Koa walk in tense silence. Carter uses the SPINE STAFF as a walking stick, the fused spines knocking softly against the path.

The world around them unfurls in folds of dreamlogic. Chapter roots split and bloom as if sensing their passage. Pages peel from dead trees, drifting in the stale, ink-heavy air like forgotten prayers.

Everything is too still.

In the distance, a clock tower ticks with no visible hands.

CARTER
(quiet)
You always punch strangers?

KOA
Only the loud ones.

Carter winces, brushing dried blood from his lip. A shared breath of tension. Not trust—but survival.

Koa eyes the staff, then the shifting ground ahead.

KOA (CONT'D)
You're going to drop that thing the second this place turns sideways.

Carter looks down at the staff, then back up.

He rips a strip of leather from a ruined binding jutting out of the path, threads it through, and slings the SPINE STAFF across his back like a makeshift pack.

KOA (CONT'D)
(practical)
Better. You're going to need both hands where we're going.

KOA (CONT'D)
Who taught you to fight?

CARTER
I didn't learn. I just... didn't want to die.

Koa doesn't respond. He keeps his eyes on the path. Something gnaws at the edge of his thoughts.

KOA
You said you're looking for two others. A girl and a boy?

CARTER
My sister. Ava. And Leo—my brother. We got pulled in. Separate places. I need to find them.

KOA
Then we don't have time.

He crouches beside a spiraled glyph etched into the path—almost pulsing. A pulse neither sees but both feel.

KOA (CONT'D)
The roots are thinning. That means this chapter's collapsing. Unwritten parts... rethreading.

CARTER
Is that a good thing or a bad thing?

KOA
Depends who finds us first.

They share a look. For the first time, a flicker of understanding.

Suddenly, a SCRAPE.

They freeze.

Just beyond the next ridge—something large, silent, and impossibly fast darts between structures made of stacked parchment and bone.

Koa draws his dagger, carved from a feather's spine.

CARTER
What is it?

KOA
One of the Book's collectors. They take memories... make them bleed.

The world seems to pull inward.

KOA (CONT'D)
Come on. If we're going to find your siblings, we need Miren.

Carter tenses at the name.

CARTER
Who is that?

KOA
Someone who doesn't let stories end.

They disappear into the shifting dark, two silhouettes crossing into the unknown.

And behind them, the creature steps forward. Hulking. Half-erased. Its face a scribbled void.

It follows.

CUT TO:

EXT. THE FORGOTTEN ARTERY - NIGHT

A mechanical HUM vibrates through the cavern air.

Leo sprints through a network of collapsed tunnels and jagged stone. His hands are torn, shirt ripped. Breathing sharp and shallow.

Behind him, distant SLITHERING. Wet. Slow. A voice not made of sound but memory coils through the stone:

VOICE (O.S.)
You were not written.

He doesn't look back.

The path twists. Narrows. Lightless.

Leo stumbles to a dead-end wall of rootflesh and cracked stone.

LEO
No. No no no—

He turns. Listens.

Something is moving. A scrape without rhythm. An intelligence that watches but never blinks.

Then, the wall behind him SHUDDERS and SPLITS OPEN. A sliver of bioluminescent glow spills out.

A DOOR. Breathing.

LEO (CONT'D)
...You've got to be kidding me.

A CHIME cuts the air.

A chorus of metallic whispers, the sound of names being unspoken.

Above: a flicker. A silhouette scuttling upside down.

Leo dives into the door.

INT. THE DOORWAY CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

Darkness. Thick and clinging.

Leo crawls forward. The walls PULSE with slow-light glyphs writhing.

Something brushes past him, not a touch, a memory. A birthday. A scream. Gone.

He gasps. Focuses. Keeps crawling.

Hands grip a stone outcropping. He hauls himself up.

The chamber opens into a circular hollow carved in a strange, inverted architecture. The ceiling curves downward like a pressed fingerprint.

In the center: a FLOATING SYMBOL. The spiral of thread and feather. Alive, pulsing.

LEO
What... are you?

From the shadows: a presence. Gentle. Familiar.

The GIRL OF THREAD steps into view.

Her body woven of iridescent silk and starlight, no eyes, but Leo knows she sees him.

GIRL OF THREAD
The Book remembers you now.

She kneels beside him, brushing her hand across the stone.

GIRL OF THREAD (CONT'D)
Here, pages bind memory to place. Speak too much — the walls will rewrite you.

LEO
Why are you helping me?

GIRL OF THREAD
Because she asked me to.

She places a thread-woven finger over his lips.

GIRL OF THREAD (CONT'D)
To be remembered here... is to be hunted.

A sudden tremor as the floating spiral flares. DOZENS OF HANDS begin to descend the walls.

Ink dripping. Covered in forgotten words.

Leo grips a nearby shard of memory-stone.

LEO
Not again—

But before he can move...

The Girl of Thread raises her hand. Threads spool outward, wrapping the walls.

The hands shatter into dust.

Leo stares, breathless.

LEO (CONT'D)
That was...

He turns. Sees past the ruined glyphs —

A moment of true awe:

Beyond a broken archway, an impossible forest rises. Trees shaped like open books. Their leaves made of constellations. Wind that carries the scent of forgotten lullabies.

Leo steps forward. Silenced. Awestruck.

The Girl of Thread offers her hand.

GIRL OF THREAD
She's waiting.

He nods.

EXT. MIRRORGLEN HIDEOUT - DAWN

A hidden alcove of stitched-stone ruins tucked behind the roots of a massive archive-tree.

MIREN MARR, (19), fierce, hollow-eyed, unbroken, stands in silhouette, one hand on a weapon shaped like a broken quill. Her other hand holds a page with Leo's feather on it.

She turns as they approach.

MIREN
Took you long enough.

Leo freezes.

LEO
Who... are you?

MIREN
Someone who needs you to survive.

A pause. The Girl of Thread steps back into the forest, dissolving into silk.

Off Leo’s stunned face, eyes locking with Miren’s...

CUT TO:

INT. THE EDITORIUM - CONTINUOUS

Towers of ink spiral into impossible arches. Paper flutters in no wind. Names scrawled across the walls, slashed out by unseen hands.

A figure kneels in the center: THE EXECUTIONER.

Armor stitched from pages. Her helmet a stitched leather mask of silence.

Before her, the BOOK.

Massive. Breathing. Shifting. Its cover made of scar tissue and memory. The pages emit a heatless glow, pulsing like a heartbeat from a dying star.

The Book hums.

A presence older than time. Divine in scale. Its spine groans as it opens, a memory tomb unlocking.

WHISPERS curl through the air. Not voices, intentions. Absolute. Irrevocable.

One page opens on its own.

Ink floods upward, shaping into trembling figures:

— LEO running through the Forgotten Artery.

— CARTER at the Spine.

— AVA in the dark.

The images blur.

Then a loud snap.

Three threads appear. Pulled tight. Fraying at the ends.

A heartbeat. Not hers. The Book's.

The EXECUTIONER rises. The air around her hardens, then fractures.

THE BOOK (WHISPERED)
Too many stories left untethered.

EXECUTIONER
Then let them be... collected.

She steps forward. Lays her hand on the threads.

They scream.

The Book trembles, its cry echoed by the chamber itself.

Walls split. Trees beyond the arches shudder violently. Ink bleeds upward from the ground.

A new page TEARS itself from the Book. It HOWLS.

From the void beyond the chamber, SOMETHING CRAWLS OUT.

THE UNRAVELER.

Its limbs are ink-bone and thorn. Its mouth hundreds of razor sharp teeth. Within them: flickers of memories trying to escape.

It waits. Shuddering. Breathing wrong.

EXECUTIONER (CONT'D)
Do not bring them whole. Bring them true.

The Unraveler bows and vanishes in a burst of paper and flame.

The Book begins to close, but not fully. It hesitates. Another whisper bleeds through:

THE BOOK
(whispered)
One has returned to her. The escaped one... and the daughter who remembers. Both must be erased.

The Executioner flinches as a flicker crosses her mask.

A memory.

A pocket watch.

A girl's laugh.

Then gone.

EXECUTIONER
(to herself - unheard)
Miren...

CUT TO:

EXT. ORCHARD OF PAPER TREES - NIGHT

The world is dying sideways.

Ava trudges through an orchard of rotting paper trees. Their leaves disintegrate with every gust. Burned symbols char the bark. Each tree holds a phrase long forgotten.

Brim limps beside her, wings dim, feathers mottled.

BRIM
We passed through here... last time.

AVA
You sure?

BRIM
(softly)
You carved something. There.

He nods toward a tree with a shallow mark: three lines crossing. A childish symbol. A memory echo.

BRIM (CONT'D)
You weren't always this quiet.

She doesn't respond. Her breath fogs. She's limping now. Hands scraped. She looks older than before, worn down by silence and grief.

BRIM (CONT'D)
You once sang here. Laughed so loud it scared the ink-bats.

AVA
That wasn't me.

They keep walking. Trees twist inward now, growing denser, wrong. The orchard narrows into a choke of warped roots and bone-white thorns.

Brim stumbles. Coughs. A dark thread leaks from one wing.

AVA (CONT'D)
Brim—

BRIM
I'm fine.

Ava falters. She drops to one knee, wheezing. Hands trembling. She forces herself upright only to collapse again.

AVA
(cracking)
I can't... I can't do this anymore.

She curls inward, shaking. Dirt and ash cling to her face.

AVA (CONT'D)
I held it together. I was strong. For Leo. For Carter. But I... I'm so tired.

She presses her forehead to the ground.

AVA (CONT'D)
I didn't cry when they died. I didn't even scream.

A long beat. Brim kneels beside her.

BRIM (GENTLY)
Then scream now.

She exhales, one breath, shattered.

Across the clearing: a RUSTLING.

A pool of glassy ink shifts. Out of it rises: THE MIRROR-CREATURE.

A humanoid shape, made of liquid reflection. Ava's silhouette mirrored back. Cracked. Haunted.

MIRROR-CREATURE
You weren't strong enough then either.

Ava flinches.

MIRROR-CREATURE (CONT'D)
You couldn't save them.

AVA
Shut up.

MIRROR-CREATURE
You're not the one who gets out.

She claws her sketchbook from her pack.

The creature lunges. Brim intercepts. A shield of broken light bursts from his wings as he tackles it away.

He crumples.

AVA
(to herself)
Don't you take him too.

Her hands blur across the sketchbook, frantic lines, desperate.

A doorway starts to form but the lines flicker. Unstable.

Ava clutches the page.

AVA (CONT'D)
I need to give you something real...

She hesitates, then closes her eyes.

FLASH MEMORY: Her mother braiding her hair, humming an old lullaby. Her grandfather's hand on her shoulder. A birthday. A song. Laughter.

She opens her eyes and draws a final line.

The door BLOOMS OPEN made of firelight and feathers.

The sketchbook page burns.

Behind her, THE MIRROR-CREATURE dissolves into smoke.

Wind whips the trees. The orchard SHRIEKS.

A beat. Ava turns and sees it.

In the distant woods, just beyond the threshold: THE UNRAVELER. Its ribs open and close like the jaws of a trap.

It watches.

Brim stirs weakly.

AVA (CONT'D)
We're not done yet.

She helps him up. Brim leans on her, barely conscious.

They step through the open door.

AVA (CONT'D)
Some things I can't carry anymore.

As they vanish, the door seals shut with a burst of flame.

CUT TO:

EXT. MIRRORGLEN - NIGHT

Moonlight shivers through a canopy of mirrored leaves. Roots coil through the ruins of an ancient archive, all parchment stone and twisted ink-veins. A faint hum pulses beneath it.

Leo stands in silence, staring at the place where the Girl of Thread vanished, her silk still lingering like dew on the branches.

LEO
Will she come back?

Miren steps into the half-light, watching him.

MIREN
Not like that.

LEO
What was she?

MIREN
One of us. A thread-runner. They move between the cracks, keep watch when the rest of us can't.

She turns, her cloak shifting like torn vellum, and walks deeper into the glen.

MIREN (CONT'D)
Come on. We don't stay in the open.

INT. MIRRORGLEN - INNER CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

Stone walls stitched with story fragments. Fractured portraits. A ceiling of old ink threads glows faintly above.

Miren moves with familiarity, this is hers. A world carved from survival.

Leo follows, slow. Eyes wide.

LEO
You said you needed me to survive.

MIREN
I did. I do.

She stops at a table littered with artifacts: a melted candle made of waxed feathers. A broken compass. A map drawn in disappearing ink.

MIREN (CONT'D)
This Chapter's folding. Faster than expected.

She turns to him and falters. Eyes narrowing.

MIREN (CONT'D)
You brought him with you.

LEO
What?

MIREN
Koa.

A silence.

LEO
I don't know who he is.

MIREN
That's not what I said.

She inhales sharply. Her hand twitches. She grips the edge of the table like it's the only thing holding her up.

MIREN (CONT'D)
I felt him. When you crossed the spindle-gate. He was on your shadow.

LEO
You… felt him?

MIREN
We're bound by more than memory.

She unrolls a page, the one she held before, and places it between them. Leo's feather is pressed into the center.

MIREN (CONT'D)
He gave this to you.

LEO (QUIET)
I don’t remember.

Miren studies him. Eyes softening, slightly.

MIREN
That’s how the Book punishes the ones it fears.

She picks up the feather, it glints with inklight, pulsing faintly.

MIREN (CONT’D)
When he vanished, I thought the story won. That we’d been erased. But this —
(she lifts the feather)
— this means the story’s unfinished.

LEO
Why me?

MIREN
Because you’re not written yet.

Leo lowers his gaze.

LEO
My brother thinks I’m broken.

MIREN
You are.

A beat.

MIREN (CONT’D)
So was I. So is Koa. That’s what makes us dangerous.

Silence stretches. Miren holds out the feather.

MIREN (CONT’D)
It’s yours. It always was.

LEO
What does it do?

MIREN
That depends on what you choose.

He takes it.

A flicker of light runs through his veins. Not magic, memory.

MIREN (CONT'D)
You don't have to know everything yet.

She steps closer. Voice lower.

MIREN (CONT'D)
But when the time comes... don't let him feed the pages.

LEO
Who?

She doesn't answer.

The lights above dim. Something rumbles in the roots below.

MIREN
It's not safe to travel at night.
We move at first light.
(a beat)
They're hunting the others. We find them before the pages do.

She turns. Cloak flicking behind her.

Leo stands alone, feather in hand, heart pounding with something he doesn't yet understand.

CUT TO:

EXT. BACKSTAGE OF THE CARNIVAL - DUSK

A broken theater of forgotten color. Carnival banners hang like torn wings, flickering as if caught between dimensions. The midway is empty, no laughter, no life. A calliope plays in reverse.

Gideon sits on the steps of the ruined bandstand. Frail. Face sunken. Eyes hollow. A man unraveling from the inside.

His fingers tremble as he holds the LOCKET.

GIDEON
(soft, cracking)
Miren...

The name bleeds into silence. His thumb brushes the worn metal. Inside: the faded photo of a woman and child. A heartbeat echoes faintly, not from him.

VOICES (O.S.)
You said we'd be saved.

VOICE 2 (O.S.)
You promised.

VOICE 3 (O.S.)
You fed us to the story.

The voices swirl. Dozens. Hundreds. Layered. Not Miren. Not Anna. The others, all the ones he sent in to die.

GIDEON
I... I was trying to open the door.

The Book doesn't answer.

Around him, the Carnival begins to collapse.

The carousel's lights blink and vanish, one bulb at a time.

Banners unwrite themselves, letters peel off like dead skin.

Marionette puppets slump. One wears Gideon's face its strings snap, limp.

Gideon coughs. Blood spills from the corner of his mouth. He wipes it. Sees it on his palm.

GIDEON (CONT'D)
You're done with me.

He blinks. His reflection in a cracked funhouse mirror shows nothing at all.

GIDEON (CONT'D)
Just let me hold on... a little longer.

A low hum begins. The sound of pages turning in reverse.

The LOCKET pulses once. He clutches it to his chest.

GIDEON (CONT'D)
Please... not yet. Not before she knows.

His voice breaks. The air around him begins to stutter a skipping reel.

The wind rises. A single whisper cuts through the storm:

WHISPER (O.S.)
You were never the author.

Everything slows.

He looks to the darkened sky. Eyes wide. Ruined. Still, he doesn’t move.

GIDEON (BARELY A WHISPER)
Miren.

FAINT LIGHT flickers in the locket. The heartbeat again.

Then BLACK lines begin to fracture up his neck, spiderwebbing across his skin.

He doesn’t fight it. He waits.

CUT TO:

EXT. EMBERGLOW FOREST - BORDERLAND - DUSK

The trees drip with twilight. Bark peels like scorched parchment. Shadows split and shimmer as if torn by invisible ink.

A bruised sky leans in.

AVA and BRIM push through broken underbrush. Ava's steps falter, her breath ragged.

AVA
(gasping)
Is it... still behind us?

BRIM doesn’t answer. He halts.

BRIM
It’s worse than that.

The earth groans.

Behind them—

The chapter curls inward. The forest—folding, burning, breaking. A black tide devours the ground like acid—trees, rocks, even light sucked into nothing.

BRIM (CONT’D)
The chapter’s collapsing.

AVA
We can still run—

BRIM
No. The Storywright’s deleting it.

This place is being erased.

The ground beneath them splits—cracks spider through the dirt.

AVA
(panicking)
I can draw us something—

She grabs her journal.

Ink. Charcoal. Desperation.

A drawing spills from her hand—an imagined door of escape.

It does not come to life.

The page curls to ash in her hands.

AVA (CONT'D)
No. No, no, no—

BRIM
(gently)
It's marked. Nothing we make here will hold.

A boom behind them. Closer now. The deletion surges forward.

They RUN.

INT. EMBERGLOW FOREST - CONTINUOUS

The world distorts.

Branches flicker. Trees skip frames—twitching like dying film. Color bleeds from the leaves.

Ava stumbles.

She sees… something in the trees.

Faces. Flickers of memory. Her mother. Her father. Leo's smile. Gone.

AVA
Brim…

Brim sees it too. The forest is remembering and forgetting at once.

Suddenly— she is there. THE GIRL OF THREAD.

She steps from between the trees—glowing with quiet power. Threads run through her like veins of silver and story.

GIRL OF THREAD
You have to come. Now.

Brim stands between her and Ava—protective, stunned.

BRIM
Threadrunner.

GIRL OF THREAD
Resistance.

Her gaze locks on Ava.

GIRL OF THREAD (CONT'D)
The story remembers you. One of the three.

Ava blinks. The ground beneath her cracks wide open.

BRIM
(to Ava, choking)
I'm sorry. I failed you—

GIRL OF THREAD
Not yet.

She slams her palm against a tree.

A seam of light. The world SPLITS.

INT. THE FORGOTTEN ARTERY - NIGHT

Dark. Pulselike.

They fall through—a hidden passage of sinew, ink, and thread. The Artery.

Storywords crawl along the walls. Symbols hover midair.

Everything here lives and dies at once.

BRIM catches Ava. Both shake.

Above—the deletion still looms. Ink drips like venom.

Malformed creatures—half-drawn ideas, erased things—screech as they dissolve into non-being.

GIRL OF THREAD
This artery won't hold.

She runs. They follow.

BRIM grabs his blade. Ava grips nothing—her tools powerless.

Pages collapse underfoot. Sounds warp.

AVA
Where are we?

GIRL OF THREAD
A place the Storywright cannot watch.

A roar.

They turn one final corner—

EXT. BROKEN ARCHWAY - NIGHT

A cracked stone arch wrapped in thread and rune.

GIRL OF THREAD
Go!

Ava dives through. Brim follows.

The Girl pauses, draws a symbol of living thread, throws it into the arch—it binds shut behind them.

The roar quiets.

BRIM
Will it hold?

GIRL OF THREAD
For now.

EXT. HIDDEN FOREST GROVE - CONTINUOUS

Silence. Magic.

The forest is still, humming. Gold light pulses through the trees like veins.

AVA
(awestruck)
What is this place?

GIRL OF THREAD
The grove. The one place they couldn’t erase.

A flicker of light in the distance—soft, golden.

GIRL OF THREAD (CONT'D)
This is where the Sundered are. Your brother. And the one who could not be unmade.

They stop. The light glows through the trees.

AVA
He's really here?

The Girl nods.

GIRL OF THREAD
We're almost there.

They stare through the brush. 50 yards away—a flicker, barely visible.

The hideout. A single breath between them and reunion.

CUT TO:

EXT. HIDDEN FOREST GROVE - NIGHT

Moonlight filters through the thread-veined trees. Stillness clings to the grove like a final breath. The golden shimmer of Miren's hideout pulses softly in the dark.

Leo stirs awake, eyes wide, breath caught.

LEO
(dazed)
A voice... Carter? And someone... laughing.

He sits up, scanning the grove, sweat on his brow.

Across from him, MIREN freezes. Her feather—still hidden beneath her sleeve—pulses faintly.

MIREN
(low)
We're being watched.

Leo rises, more alert now.

LEO
What?

MIREN
The feeling shifted. Something crossed in. The Book knows where we are.

She moves to the edge of the grove, steady and poised.

MIREN (CONT'D)
We have to leave the grove now.

From beyond the treeline—figures appear.

AVA. BRIM. THE GIRL OF THREAD.

Ava sees Leo. Her breath catches.

AVA
Leo?

Leo stumbles forward—then runs.

They collide in a desperate, breathless embrace.

LEO
You're alive.

AVA
You too—

LEO
Where's Carter?

Ava freezes. Her arms drop.

AVA
I—I lost him. I thought he was behind me—I don't know—

Leo pulls back, his eyes searching hers. A storm of fear, guilt, and confusion.

LEO
We have to find him.

Behind them, BRIM drops to one knee before Miren. He has never seen her before, but knows exactly who she is.

BRIM
The one who could not be erased.

Miren studies him.

MIREN
Who are you?

BRIM
I was once a Knight of Threadlight. Before I was rewritten. You're real.

THE GIRL OF THREAD steps forward. Her pale eyes land on Leo.

Leo freezes. His breath catches.

LEO
You came back.

The Girl of Thread meets his gaze, silent, luminous.

THE GIRL OF THREAD
Not in this form... but I never truly left you. And I never truly will.

LEO
You said you wouldn't let me be erased.

THE GIRL OF THREAD
And I meant it.

They hold eye contact. A bond so deep, it vibrates through the grove.

Suddenly, MIREN staggers.

MIREN
This isn't right.

She looks to Brim and the Girl of Thread.

MIREN (CONT'D)
Tell me this isn't happening. You feel it too.

Brim nods grimly.

BRIM
The protections are fading.

The air trembles.

Objects around them begin to transform—flowers curl into blank pages, stones unravel into thread. The hideout flickers.

THE GIRL OF THREAD
The deletion reached the grove.

A pulse, bright and sharp, erupts from Leo’s side.

He looks down. His feather glows, brilliant, searing. Threads hum around it.

LEO
It’s never done this before.

THE GIRL OF THREAD
It’s reacting to the crossing.
You’re close to the end.

MIREN
We can’t stay. This place is dying.

The forest howls.

THE GIRL OF THREAD
Follow me.

She runs.

EXT. ANCIENT TREE - MOMENTS LATER

The Girl of Thread slams her palm into the bark of a gnarled ancient tree.

THE GIRL OF THREAD
(whispers)
Let them pass.

The roots shift, shimmer, and split—revealing a spiral passage downward. A ladder of glowing roots descends into darkness.

BRIM
Go!

They descend.

INT. CRYSTAL VEIN CAVES - CONTINUOUS

They land in a cavern of glimmering crystal threads and dark stone.

The air shudders. Above them, the tree is ripped from the earth.

A shriek tears through the cave.

THE UNRAVELER.

Its massive, twisted form claws downward—ink and teeth and flailing limbs of forgotten stories.

They RUN.

The corridor twists and warps. Pages peel off the walls. Screams echo from ahead and behind.

THE GIRL OF THREAD skids to a halt at a collapsing corridor. She spins—chanting a spell in the lost tongue.

She reaches back—grabbing MIREN's arm.

THE GIRL OF THREAD
You must cross the sacred bridge. It's the only way to the next chapter.

MIREN
What about you?

The Unraveler crashes in—its maw opening.

THE GIRL OF THREAD lifts both arms. Her entire form glows, threads snapping from her body as she pours every ounce of power into the collapsing tunnel.

THE GIRL OF THREAD
Run.

She looks at Leo—one last time.

THE GIRL OF THREAD (CONT'D)
(staggered, soft)
Remember me.

The Unraveler's jaws close over her.

Screams.

Shredded threads spiral through the air. Her light gone.

LEO
NO!

Miren raises her feather.

A circle of golden script ignites midair.

MIREN
NOW!

They leap—

Blinding light explodes in shards—searing, celestial.

Then—

Silence.

Nothing.

CUT TO:

EXT. THE SPINE BETWEEN CHAPTERS — NIGHT

Darkness bleeds from every crack in the torn horizon. The Spine of the Book winds upward like a snapped vertebra, a bridge of bone, root, and ink suspended over the void.

Carter and Koa climb its jagged path, every motion labored. The SPINE STAFF thumps against his back in the sling as he climbs.

Below them, fragments of dead Chapters churn like ash in water. Above them, something waits, unseen, but pulling.

KOA
No turning back now.

CARTER
Wasn't planning to.

They push forward in silence. The marrow beneath their feet pulses faintly, like the last heartbeat of something dying. Wind slips through the torn air, carrying whispers and pages torn mid-sentence.

Carter slows, pressing a hand to the bonewall.

CARTER (CONT'D)
The climb hurts.

Koa doesn't look back. His face is stone.

KOA
It's supposed to.

Their breaths cloud. The air tastes of static and memory. Carter winces, leg cramping, fingers raw, but pushes on.

Then—

Carter stops. Something juts from a crack in the bone, a weather-worn journal, stitched shut with dark thread.

CARTER
Got something.

He pries it free. Dust exhales upward. The cover trembles faintly. Inside, half-erased pages, like the thoughts of someone forgotten mid-sentence.

He squints. Between broken lines of ink — a map, concealed in negative space. Shapes unfold. A glyph pulses like a heartbeat beneath the page. Carter touches it.

FLASH: LEO and AVA running across a shimmer bridge made of mirrored light. Shadows twist behind them. The world fractures.

CARTER (CONT'D)
They're there.

Koa steps closer. The air sharpens.

KOA
Sacred Bridge.

CARTER
We can reach them.

Koa says nothing. His hand curls unconsciously, trembles. Then, a sound from below. Small. Terrible.

A child's cry.

Koa freezes.

KOA
That voice...

Carter looks to him and sees it. The crack in him. The memory breaking open.

KOA (CONT'D)
That's the voice I couldn't save.
When the Book took her.

CARTER
Who?

Koa doesn't answer.

KOA
A child I tried to lead out. She
trusted me. I failed her.

I broke the rules. I thought I could save them all.

The cry echoes again.

KOA (CONT'D)
It's a trap. It always is.

CARTER
Then let it be a trap.

CARTER (CONT'D)
If they're being called... then we're close.

Suddenly, the Spine quakes. A sharp lurch. Carter stumbles.

KOA
Keep moving.

They scramble higher. Bone shifts underfoot. Marrow trembles. Ink-threads snap. Carter reaches for a handhold and misses.

Koa turns too late, Carter falls.

KOA (CONT'D)
Carter!

Carter flails, catches the edge of Koa's arm. Koa grabs hold but slips too, dragged halfway off. The wind screams beneath them.

Their hands begin to slide apart.

CARTER
I swear — on their names — I won't let go!

Suddenly, a jolt of light.

Blue. Ancient. Resonant.

Carter's palm pulses with a glyph. Threads of ink tighten like a lattice. The bones shift, wrapping upward, bracing both of them.

KOA
Oathbound.

He pulls Carter up.

CARTER
What?

KOA
You're one of the three. From before.

CARTER
Gideon said he didn’t know...

KOA
He lied.

They don’t speak for a moment. Their faces bathed in flickering glyphlight.

KOA (CONT’D)
The Storywright’s collapsing the Chapter. Deleting everything. No one survives a full collapse.

CARTER
Then we don’t stop.

They climb again, harder now. The journal tucked into Carter’s coat, the SPINE STAFF slung over his shoulder. Their hands bloodied, faces pale.

Marrow creatures stir from their hollows, made of broken words, torn names, slivered thoughts. Shifting and unfinished.

FORGOTTEN CREATURES (V.O.)
The Hunter has returned...

Their voices scrape like rusted ink. They do not move to strike, only to witness.

CARTER
They know you.

KOA
They know who I failed to be.

CARTER
We all failed someone.

A whisper now, not from the Spine. From memory.

GIRL (V.O.)
You said you’d come back.

Carter falters. That voice, the unfinished Chapter.

KOA
Who was she?

CARTER
The story I ran from.

Rain. A promise I didn’t keep.

KOA
Then maybe this place brought us both back to finish something.

The wind grows sharp. They reach the final ledge.

A DOOR waits, carved into bone, ancient, scarred, almost alive. A lock of living ink coils across its surface.

Carter lifts the map.

CARTER
It’s a puzzle.

KOA
Then solve it.

Carter touches the symbols, they writhe and resist.

THE BOOK (V.O.)
To find what is lost... something must be left behind.

KOA
What’s it saying?

CARTER
It wants a truth.

A piece of me.

KOA
Then give it what it needs.

Carter breathes.

CARTER
I left someone in the rain. A girl I loved.

I said I’d return. I didn’t.

One glyph burns. Another blooms.

The lock unfurls. The door groans open.

Beyond: a vortex of shifting Chapters, wild, unfinished.

KOA
Only one way through.

CARTER
Then we don’t miss it.

They step through.

The door vanishes behind them.

CUT TO:

EXT. THE SACRED BRIDGE BETWEEN CHAPTERS - NIGHT

The CHAPTER fractures behind them, ink, light, and memory folding inward.

Leo, Ava, Miren, and Brim explode from the fading portal, stumbling onto a BRIDGE OF LIGHT AND BONE suspended in the void. The air HISS-CRACKS with static.

Below: the broken wreckage of stories never finished, libraries drowned in ink, homes half-drawn, characters with no names.

Above: a skyless hush, cracked by thunder made of screams.

They don't look back. They RUN.

The BRIDGE shifts beneath them, scenes flickering in and out: A birthday party. A funeral. A bed they once shared. An argument. A goodbye.

AVA
What is this place?

MIREN
The crossing. Between what was...
and what might survive.

The bridge GROANS underfoot.

Beneath their steps, unfinished pages WHISPER. Faces form in the planks — forgotten friends, half-finished sentences. The bridge starts to unravel at the edges.

Behind them: the CHAPTER collapses into nothingness.

Ahead— A FIGURE steps onto the far side of the bridge. Draped in shadow.

THE UNRAVELER.

A hunched mass of pages, teeth, and eyes sewn shut with story-thread. It GLIDES forward, twitching, sniffing the air of memory.

They stop, breathless.

MIREN (CONT'D)
No. Not here.

The bridge SHUDDERS.

Then— A SCREAM.

From behind: A STORM of MEMORY tears open, howling through broken scenes. A vortex of grief.

The moment of their PARENTS' DEATH.

FLASHES: Hands reaching. Fire. Screams. Mangled wreckage. A woman's voice calling for her children. Sirens. A door slamming. Rain. Blood.

The memory EXPLODES, ripping into the bridge.

The Unraveler SHRIEKS. PAGES fly forward like shrapnel, SLASHING INTO LEO.

He's lifted, limbs convulsing midair.

MIREN (CONT'D)
LEO!

Leo's body begins to glitch, chunks of him turning to static.

His NAME stutters from Miren's lips.

MIREN (CONT'D)
Fi-fight it, Leo! Use it—use the feather!

Leo stares at the feather in his hand. It GLOWS. Then flickers. His FINGERS are VANISHING.

AVA
(screaming)
LEO!!

Brim doesn't think.

He RUNS. Faster than we've ever seen him.

BRIM
HEY!!

He HURLS himself at the Unraveler, crashing into its chest of pages.

The creature stumbles.

Brim LEAPS, catches Leo’s leg, his arms tremble under the pull of the storm.

BRIM (CONT’D)
(gritting his teeth)
I got you... I got you...

The storm ROARS, clawing at them both. Leo's name starts to TEAR from his chest, we hear it RIPPING out of memory.

BRIM (CONT’D)
(straining)
You don’t forget him. You don’t!

The Unraveler SCREECHES, recovering. It launches forward.

Brim looks to Ava, her face frozen in terror.

He smiles.

BRIM (CONT’D)
It’s been my honor.

A pause.

BRIM (CONT’D)
Now find a way to survive.

And he LETS GO.

He SHOVES LEO back toward the others and SPINS, tackling the Unraveler mid-charge.

They PLUNGE together, off the edge of the bridge, VANISHING into the chasm of death.

AVA
NO—!!

She COLLAPSES — A scream caught in her throat.

The bridge begins to buckle.

Miren SCREAMS — her feather IGNITES.

She GRABS Leo’s dissolving wrist.

MIREN
STAY WITH ME, LEO!

A SHOCKWAVE rips across the storm.

Leo’s eyes ROLL BACK — his body folding in on itself —

We SEE IT: A MEMORY RIPPED FROM LEO — A rainy afternoon, Ava hugging him tight. Her saying:

AVA (V.O.)
I believe in you, always.

It shatters.

Miren's feather BURNS WHITE-HOT, veins of gold cracking her skin.

She BLEEDS from her nose, her mouth, her voice BREAKS—

MIREN
You don't get to take him!!

She POURS herself into the connection as the bridge fractures further.

Leo is SCREAMING as the storm violently pulls him back into the air.

The light between them SURGES, a blinding, radiant surge.

And then— MIREN IS THROWN BACK.

Her body SLAMS against the bone of the bridge, blood sprays, her limbs go limp.

She collapses.

The feather drifts beside her, SMOKING, FADING.

The CHAPTER behind them is gone.

Only the bridge remains and it is CRACKING.

The DARKNESS OF DEATH begins to seep across its veins, crawling toward them.

Ava crawls to Miren.

AVA
Miren—

She's barely breathing.

CUT TO:

EXT. SACRED BRIDGE — FRACTURED REALITY

A BLINDING SURGE OF MYTHIC LIGHT.

Koa ERUPTS from a spiraling vortex, torn, bloodied, glitching. Time stutters around his body. In his hand: the MAP.

Behind him, Carter stumbles out of the light, breathless, eyes wide at the horror unfolding.

Ahead: the storm rages.

Leo is suspended mid-air, SCREAMING. Limbs convulsing. Threaded lines of ink rip at his skin, tearing him apart.

Miren lies unconscious.

Ava, bloodied, clutches the splintering edge of the bridge.

CARTER
(shouting)
LEO!

Carter SPRINTS. Pure instinct. No thought.

The STORM WINDS catch him, whip him up, slam him sideways. He hits the stone HARD. Crumples. Spits blood. Doesn't rise.

Koa STAGGERS FORWARD, breath ragged, eyes on the chaos, and plants himself between the STORM and the others.

KOA
(yelling into the void)
TAKE ME INSTEAD!

The STORM HESITATES. Time fractures. Lightning halts mid-flash. A soundless vacuum falls over the bridge.

Koa glows, threads of mythic light etching across his skin. The sky shatters into chapter-marked fractures. The darkness of death swallows half the bridge.

He turns.

Ava bleeding.

Carter broken.

Leo screaming, dissolving.

And Miren— Her eyes flutter open.

KOA (CONT'D)
(soft)
I'm so sorry, Miren.

He reaches inside his coat. Pulls out the MATCHBOX.

The storm screams louder.

KOA (CONT'D)
You said I'd never carry fire again...

He grips it tight. Then FLINGS it into the heart of the storm.

Stillness.

Then, he whispers:

KOA (CONT'D)
My name is... Kaelan.

The storm SHRIEKS. The BOOK HEARS.

Everything pauses.

Lightning freezes. The bridge trembles. The sky pulses like an open wound.

Leo's BODY begins to split at the seams. Limbs unravel. His mouth opens in a silent scream.

Koa closes his eyes.

KOA (CONT'D)
Tell her... I tried to write something better...

A beat. THE STORM ACCEPTS.

Leo DROPS, gasping. Alive.

Koa IS LIFTED, wind and ink ripping around his body. His form fracturing, pulled in every direction.

A symphony of pain. Pages tear from the air. A hand of ink, a mouth of pages, rise to devour him.

The sky WHISPERS:

THE BOOK (V.O.)
Kaelan...

And then, A SHATTERING DETONATION.

The BRIDGE folds.

The STORM ruptures.

The WORLD turns like a page.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. COLLAPSED LIBRARY - DESERT CHAPTER — NIGHT

SILENCE.

The group drops into an alien world of cracked marble and sand-filled aisles. Shattered books hover weightless. Light falls like snow.

Miren stumbles forward. Crawling.

She finds him.

Koa. Broken. Barely breathing. Hollowed.

His eyes stare past her. Empty.

MIREN
No. No no no no no—

She clutches him. Sobs. Rocking.

MIREN (CONT'D)
Don't die. Please. You can't— you can't leave me again.
(whispers)
You were the ending I never got.
You were the ending I needed.

She buries her face in his chest.

Around them: drifting ash turns into glowing words. Pages curl into embers.

Across the ruins—

Leo and Carter stir. Broken. Dazed.

Ava rushes to them. Drops to her knees. Pulls them into her arms.

They hold each other tight. Like survivors of a forgotten myth.

Miren and Ava lock eyes. They are alive. But broken.

INT. COLLAPSED LIBRARY - DESERT CHAPTER - NIGHT

A hush. The world is broken.

Sand settles. Torn shelves lie half-buried. Marble statues are cracked at the throat, their faces erased by wind. Shattered books float mid-air, frozen in a surreal stillness.

The echo of the bridge storm is gone.

Just silence.

Carter leans against a broken pillar, coughing dust, the staff lies blackened besides him. Leo hunches forward, breathing hard. The three siblings stay close, a triad of bruises, dirt, and breath.

Koa lies nearby. Still. His body glitches faintly, threads of ink flickering in and out.

Miren kneels beside him. Watches. Hands trembling.

She touches his face, barely.

MIREN
(low, scanning the library)
We're still inside. It tried to spit us out... and missed.
(beat)
... now, pieces of the past are coming back.

She glances up. The sky is parchment-dark. No stars.

Carter shifts, winces.

CARTER
(dry)
That was spitting?

A weak attempt at levity. It lands like a stone.

The silence swells again. A low hum pulses beneath it.

Leo sways, trying to steady himself.

Miren stands slowly, taking in the space, the broken archways, the trembling air. Her gaze falls on drifting ash turning into words mid-float. She says nothing.

A beat.

LEO
Ava, you're bleeding.

AVA
(scoffing it off)
It’s nothing.

She kneels beside Koa. Concern on her face. Her fingers shake.

She doesn’t say anything.

LEO
(sincerely)
You can stop now.

Ava freezes.

Something in her face shifts. Her eyes fall on something half-buried in the sand.

A compass. Rusted. Cracked. Familiar.

She stares at it.

AVA
(quiet)
I can’t.

The tears hit like a body blow.

Her shoulders buckle. She sits back against a shattered shelf, breath hitching, hands trembling, blood drying on her lip.

No elegance. No armor.

She cries like someone who forgot how.

Carter shifts closer but doesn’t touch her.

Even the air holds its breath.

Miren watches. Silent.

KOA
(murmuring)
Miren...

Barely a whisper. Then silence again.

The sound of torn pages fluttering through air.

CUT TO:

INT. THE SPINE - THE BOOK'S INNER WORLD - NIGHT

Silence.

A world unspooling: torn parchment ripples in slow motion beneath a cracked vellum sky, scorched with streaks of black lightning. No horizon. No gravity. Just the echo of something that was.

Where the UNRAVELER once stood is now a hole, not just torn, but ABSENT. A jagged, pulsing wound in the Book itself.

Black ink-drips float upward into that nothing, vanishing like whispers.

A heartbeat thumps.

Then fades.

In the stillness, echoing faintly —

KOA (V.O.)
My name is… KAELAN.

The name reverberates like a spell that refuses to die.

EXT. HANGING PAGES - INNER SPINE

A single floating page, blank.

Ink bleeds across its surface:

KAELAN

KAELAN

KAELAN
Typed. Scratched. Burned in. Fonts shift. Sizes distort. Then all variations collapse into one single name:

KAELAN.

Bold. Centered. The edges begin to singe.

The ink warps. Lines curl. Letters bend.

The name folds into a SIGIL: a circular glyph, part compass, part target, part hunter's mark.

From its center, veins of ink shoot outward into the surrounding pages.

MONTAGE - INK MAPPING

- A map forms: abstract chapter fragments drawn in moving ink.

- Carnival. Mines. Forgotten Library. Bridge.

- The veins pulse, searching — reaching.

- They slam into a static-filled blind zone: the new desert-library chapter.

- The ink falters, writhes at the edge, unable to enter.

INT. CHAMBER OF EMPTY CHAPTERS - ELSEWHERE IN THE BOOK

The EXECUTIONER kneels beneath torn pages. Her armor is cracked, blackened. Ash flakes drift like snow.

Voices spiral through the air, not spoken but WRITTEN.

WHISPERED TEXT (V.O.)
Kaelan… Kaelan… Kaelan…

The sigil burns into the air above her hand.

She looks up. Tilts her head. For a second, something almost human flashes behind the stitched mask — recognition, loss — then it’s gone.

A voice, calm and cruel, scrawls itself across the air.

THE BOOK (V.O.)
The Hunter has given me his name.

The sigil glows brighter. The Executioner closes her fingers around it.

EXECUTIONER
(softly)
Then we can find him.

INSERT PAGE ON THE MAP: The name-sigil extends a thread into the parchment. A leash of ink.

It reaches the blind zone. Presses.

Static flickers. The leash strains — but can’t yet enter.

The thread pulls taut.

A whisper, more felt than heard —

THE BOOK (O.S.)
Every name has a thread.

CUT BACK TO:

INT. COLLAPSED LIBRARY - NEAR THE FIRE - LATER

A hush blankets the broken library. The wind has quieted, but the air still glows faintly, as if the pages themselves remember.

A small fire crackles, made from warped wood, frayed bindings, and a spark of resonance.

Miren crouches beside it, coaxing it to life. She glances back.

Ava sits with her back turned, still within view, curled inward, silent, eyes on something invisible. Her shoulders quake, but she's making no sound.

MIREN
Let her breathe.

She rises, quietly guides Leo, who hovers mid-step, torn between the fire and his sister.

MIREN (CONT'D)
He needs something more than bandages.

She nods toward Carter, who sits slumped against a broken arch. Wrapped in gauze, dried blood on his temple.

Leo hesitates, then crosses the fractured marble floor and lowers himself beside Carter.

LEO
(quietly)
The more I try not to remember... the more the memories bleed through.

Carter looks at him but says nothing. For a moment, neither speaks. Only the sound of fire. Cracking sand. Pages drifting above like broken wings.

CARTER
(gruff, automatic)
We're okay. We're alive. That's what matters.

It hangs there.

Leo doesn’t answer. Just looks at the flames. The shadows playing on his hands.

LEO
You don’t have to do that.

Carter shifts.

LEO (CONT’D)
The... "we’re fine" thing.

Carter smirks, almost.

CARTER
It’s what I do.

LEO
I know.

Beat.

LEO (CONT’D)
But you don’t have to.

A long silence. Carter exhales. The fire pops.

CARTER
(quiet)
I don’t know what I’m doing.

He doesn't look at Leo when he says it. Just watches the fire.

CARTER (CONT’D)
I keep thinking there’s a way to fix this. That if I hold it together long enough... we’ll get back to before.

A beat.

CARTER (CONT’D)
But there’s no before. Not anymore.

Leo doesn’t fill the silence. He just sits with it.

The two of them in half-light, one unraveling, one listening.

Firelight flickers. Shadows stretch long.

Beat.

CARTER (CONT'D)
(quiet)
There was a girl.

Leo turns slightly. Doesn't speak.

CARTER (CONT'D)
First time I ended up here — the Book — it was raining. I don't know where I was, not really. Just... cold. Wet. Lost.
(beat)
And she found me.

He swallows hard.

CARTER (CONT'D)
She held my hand. Led me toward something. Said we weren't done yet. I didn't know what that meant — I still don't.
(beat)
But I ran.

Leo looks at him, really looks.

CARTER (CONT'D)
I left her. Just bolted. Didn't even look back. And I've been running ever since.

No response. Just the sound of flame and wind sifting sand through stone.

LEO
(softly)
I remember her.

Carter finally meets his eyes.

LEO (CONT'D)
I think I saw her too. The first time. Or maybe... some part of her.
(beat)
The Executioner came for me. I could've said my name. I wanted to. But I choked. Froze.
(beat)
I thought... that's why the Book wants me. Why everything breaks. Why people get hurt.

Carter doesn't interrupt. Just listens.

LEO (CONT'D)
I thought I was the flaw.

Silence. Raw. Unfixed.

CARTER
You're not.
(beat)
Neither of us are. We just—

He falters. Tries again.

CARTER (CONT'D)
We both messed up. That doesn't mean this is over.

A long pause. Then, slowly, Leo leans into his brother's shoulder.

Carter doesn't pull away.

ANGLE ON —

Ava, near the fire. Her eyes swollen, but dry now. She reaches into the folds of her coat — pulls out a crumpled scrap of paper.

Her hand trembles.

She smooths the paper on a stone slab. Finds a bit of charcoal. Begins to draw, small, tentative lines.

Three rough shapes begin to emerge.

She stares at them. Doesn't smile. Doesn't cry.

But she doesn't stop.

ANGLE ON —

The fire.

The two brothers.

Ava's drawing, still in progress.

CUT TO:

INT. COLLAPSED LIBRARY - NIGHT

Night has settled deeper.

The fire crackles steady — a flickering core in a sea of shadow.

Above, pages drift like ash, like snow. Weightless. Slow. Their movement is not wind-driven — it's chosen. Each one catches a glint of firelight, glowing faint gold before floating on. Unburned.

MIREN watches the drift. Quiet. Still.

She notices: Some pages carry marks, half-lines of dialogue, almost-names, sketches that fade as they turn.

A page lands gently beside CARTER and LEO.

They both look.

The ink ripples. Not drawn. Not written. Alive.

It shows: a GIRL IN THE RAIN. CARTER — younger, soaked — running away from her. But this time, he stops.

CARTER stares. Breathing shallow.

The page curls. Burns at the edge, but does not vanish.

Another, floats near AVA.

She reaches without thinking. It shivers in her fingers.

A glimpse: YOUNGER AVA drawing an exit. Stopping. Refusing to step through. Turning back. A vow in her eyes.

AVA's face shifts. Like something painful finding form.

The page flutters loose. Escapes her grip.

Another drifts toward LEO. It lands at his feet.

The EXECUTIONER towers in ink, a shadow demanding a name. YOUNG LEO opens his mouth. Tries to speak. Nothing.

The moment glitches. Freezes. The page quivers — unfinished.

LEO stares. Swallows.

By the fire, Miren watches them all. The inked fragments swirl in the air around her like a silent tide.

She speaks. Soft. Clear.

MIREN
We're not broken.
(beat)
(MORE)

MIREN (CONT'D)
We're unfinished, but bound together.

The fire pops.

CARTER looks at his hand, the glyph faint on his skin. Ava touches her jacket, fingers finding the sketch inside. Leo's gaze stays on the page, still waiting for a name.

Silence.

The world holds its breath.

FADE OUT.

EXT. COLLAPSED LIBRARY - NEAR THE FIRE - NIGHT

The fire burns lower now, embers casting long shadows against the broken stone and collapsed shelves. Pages still drift in the air — slower, like the world is holding its breath.

Miren sits cross-legged, watching the flames with a faraway expression.

The others rest in silence behind her. Koa still unconscious. Ava curled beside the fire, arms around her knees. Carter and Leo half-asleep against fallen stone.

Miren doesn't look back. Just speaks, low and certain.

MIREN
The resistance isn't gone. Just... scattered.

She reaches into her coat. Pulls out a glass vial of ink — shimmering, silver-black.

MIREN (CONT'D)
The Book tried to burn every thread that didn't serve it. But some of us survived. In the in-between.

She uncorks the vial. Tips a drop into her palm.

MIREN (CONT'D)
If there's anyone left... this is the page they need to hear about.

She presses her inked palm to the ground.

The ink flares softly, then snakes outward — forming a small symbol in the sand: a circle with radiating lines.

It shivers.

And then — From the center, thin luminous threads unfurl — spider-fast, spider-small. They dart into cracks and shadows, zigzagging out of view.

THREAD-RUNNERS. Tiny streaks of living ink and light. Fast. Secret. Each one pulsing with urgency.

MIREN (CONT'D)
The unwritten ones are at the last chapter. If you're still out there... come.

She watches the last of them vanish into the dark.

Beat.

Beyond the firelight, in the rubble and shadow, two small creatures stir.

No one notices them.

They are delicate, moth-like. Made of folded paper and ink, wings humming with faint script.

They stare at KOA's still form.

BOOK CREATURE #1 (WHISPERS)
The Hunter...

BOOK CREATURE #2
He was supposed to be a myth.

BOOK CREATURE #1
He came back.

The fire cracks.

A breeze stirs the drifting pages, and somewhere, far beyond, the threads keep running.

FADE OUT.

INT. COLLAPSED LIBRARY - DAWN

A different kind of quiet.

What passes for morning in this chapter bleeds through the torn ceiling — not sunlight, but a pale, fractured glow leaking from the sky-cracks overhead. It shifts in color, soft and bone-pale. Light without heat. Daybreak without mercy.

The fire is down to embers.

AVA sleeps curled near it, dried streaks on her cheeks, one hand half-closed around her sketch scrap.

CARTER dozes against a pillar, chest rising slow, bandage showing beneath torn layers.

LEO lies on his side nearby, between them. Not by accident.

MIREN is already awake.

She kneels beside KOA. Still breathing. Still here.

But the light catches threads of ink coiled faintly beneath his skin. His gaze is open but not seeing. A body holding on, half-emptied.

Miren leans in. Checks his pulse, his breath. Whispers—

MIREN
You're still here.

She exhales. Shaky.

MIREN (CONT'D)
That's really unfair, you know.

No response. Not really.

She watches him. The faintest ripple of ink traces across his throat and vanishes.

She tries again.

MIREN (CONT'D)
You used to hum when you lied.
(beat)
You still owe me a bowl of stew.

Silence. Then—

A twitch. One corner of his mouth lifts. Barely. A hum. Cracked and short, more breath than melody.

But it's enough.

Miren blinks hard. Doesn't wipe the tear.

She looks over her shoulder — at the three siblings asleep in the ruins. The echo of Koa's last stand held in their breathing.

She swallows.

MIREN (CONT'D)
You got them this far.
(softly)
Let's see if we can do the rest without breaking you.

She turns back to him, hand hovering just over his.

The glow above shifts slightly bluer.

FADE OUT.

INT. COLLAPSED LIBRARY SANCTUARY - DAWN

Light filters in through the cracked dome above like breath held too long. Not sunrise—just a soft, pearled glow bleeding through seams in the parchment sky.

The fire is down to whispers. Ash cools the sand. Silence, except for the turning of a distant page.

LEO stirs first.

He blinks at the fragments of morning. Sees: -- MIREN crouched at KOA's side. -- AVA, curled up near the embers, brow finally uncreased. -- CARTER, half-seated, head tipped forward, still asleep.

Leo doesn't speak. He reaches over and nudges Carter's arm.

CARTER
(grunts, waking)
What--?

He tenses. Looks around.

Then sees them: Leo, Ava. Safe.

A breath he didn't realize he was holding slips out. He nods.

AVA stirs next.

Her hand moves instinctively to her side. Finds the folded scrap of sketch paper. She checks it—the faint marks still there. Three rough figures, half-born.

A flicker of something passes over her face. Relief? Or fear it might vanish.

CARTER (CONT'D)
(starts to speak)
Okay. We need to--

He stops. Eyes flick between them. He breathes. Tries again.

CARTER (CONT'D)
How are you guys?

Beat. Leo just shrugs. Ava smirks.

AVA
On a scale of one to Book-fucked?

They almost smile.

CARTER
(chuckles, quiet)
Right.

They sit there. Three kids on the edge of what used to be a story.

LEO
So...

AVA
What now? We run? We fight? Do we even know what we're trying to get back to?

Beat.

AVA (CONT'D)
I keep seeing something.

They turn to her.

AVA (CONT'D)
Not like a dream. More like... a drawing. Same one, over and over, every time I close my eyes.

She pulls the scrap closer.

AVA (CONT'D)
The Book finishes our chapter.

A beat. She traces the paper with one finger.

AVA (CONT'D)
I see Carter. Standing. Same stance, same glare. Unbending.

Carter flinches.

AVA (CONT'D)
Me—turned to stone. Shielding both of you. Can't move. Can't speak.

LEO
And me?

AVA
Ink. Dissolving. No face, no voice.

She looks up. Her voice steady.

AVA (CONT'D)
I think it's the ending it wants. One it's been trying to write over us.

Silence.

AVA (CONT'D)
If we follow the ending it wants... we die. Maybe not our bodies. Us.

Off her words, they sit still. And the faint morning light, too soft to be trusted, settles over them like the pause before a page turns.

INT. COLLAPSED LIBRARY - NEAR THE DEAD FIRE - DAWN

The chapter's false dawn glows faint through fractured sky-cracks—no sun, just a colorless shimmer. Ink-motes drift like lazy ash.

Ava holds the sketch. Her hand tightens.

AVA
I don't want to be what the Book made me.

As the words leave her—

—THE AIR DENSES. Ink-motes swirl faster. Ava's drawing (three rough silhouettes) trembles.

In Leo's palm, the SIXTH FEATHER pulses.

Across from him, beneath Miren's collar—

—the FIFTH FEATHER flares.

LEO
(barely a whisper)
It's doing it again...

Ava instinctively reaches for his hand. He doesn’t pull away.

Carter tracks both feathers—eyes narrowing. This isn’t just Leo.

Beside the fire—

Koa jolts. Just a twitch—

—but his eyes go wide, flooded with white-ink. A beat.

Something else stares out.

Then—

He blinks. Breath catches. Focus returns—first to Miren. Then the kids. Then the fire.

Miren's on him instantly, hand against his cheek.

MIREN
Hey. Stay with me. You’re here.

The light brushes Koa’s face again. His posture shifts, muscle memory snapping toward something sharper—hunter-rigid—

—then falters. He breathes out. Stays still.

Leo’s feather flickers. So does Miren’s.

She rises slowly. Moves toward the glow.

Fingers trace the feather beneath her collar.

MIREN (CONT’D)
(quiet, to Leo)
There were six. Six feathers for the Sundered. Four are gone. Overwritten.
(a beat)
You and I are what’s left.

The Book crackles faintly in the silence.

MIREN (CONT’D)
It loves its shapes. The Hero. The Martyr. The Monster. The Guide. The Victim.

She nods at each sibling.

MIREN (CONT’D)
(to Carter)
Oathbound.
(MORE)

MIREN (CONT'D)
(to Ava)
Beast-Breaker.
(to Leo, as the feather flares)
Inkbound.

A pause.

MIREN (CONT'D)
It never got to finish the definitions.

They absorb it. The air feels stretched—like the Book is listening.

MIREN (CONT'D)
The pages whispered about three who escaped. Not as heroes. As a problem. A story that got away.

Beat.

CARTER stares at his hand. His glyph faint.

AVA watches her sketch still shivering in her grasp.

LEO tightens around the feather.

Their history doesn't fit the roles:

—CARTER ran instead of saving. —AVA destroyed monsters but guarded broken ones. —LEO never gave the Executioner his name.

KOA listens. Something flickers deep. The name the Book gave him still lingers.

KOA
(low)
It named me Hunter. It never asked what I wanted to be.

The sixth feather glows brighter.

Miren's fifth burns in answer.

Their light arcs outward—

—casting three layered SHADOWS against the shattered wall.

Not hero. Not martyr. Not monster.

Something else.

MIREN
Even in here, it still can't decide what to make of you.

AVA
So we're not the heroes of its story.

LEO
We're the unwritten ones.

Miren breathes in. Steady. Soft.

MIREN
You three. The ones it never finished. The ones it can't.

Silence.

The three siblings sit in the echo of it. The feather light holding.

Unwritten.

Koa stares at the glow—not part of it, but close.

FADE OUT.

INT. COLLAPSED LIBRARY RUINS - DAWN SHIFT

The glow from the feathers settles to a steady pulse—low, alive, like a heartbeat echoing through the bones of the ruined chapter.

Miren rises, the firelight catching the edge of her expression—not just wary now. Focused.

She looks from Carter to Ava to Leo... then to Koa, half-shadowed. Finally, to the fractured stacks arching in the distance.

MIREN
The Book's sick because of what it didn't finish. It stitches itself closed with stolen endings. And it devours anything that doesn't fit.

She takes a step closer, voice sharper with clarity now.

MIREN (CONT'D)
That's why Gideon kept sending people in. Why the Storywright keeps forcing roles.

Koa speaks, rough but certain.

KOA
It won't stop until it gets one.
From you. Or from me.

No drama. Just the truth.

Miren kneels. Draws with a charred bit of broken shelf in the dust.

A rough circle. A jagged wound near its center. Points radiating outward—familiar echoes of the Carnival gates, fractured.

MIREN
This is the Chapter we're in. This is the Heart. That storm you felt? It's writing your ending.

She jabs the charcoal into the sketch.

MIREN (CONT'D)
So we go there. Not to kill the Book. To tear out the page it's writing about you.

Carter steps forward, arms crossed. His voice measured.

CARTER
If we break that page—what happens to everything else?

Miren doesn't flinch. No comfort. Just honesty.

MIREN
It collapses. Or it heals. Or it changes.

She looks directly at him.

MIREN (CONT'D)
Right now, it owns your ending. We take that away, it chokes.

A silence. Heavy.

CARTER
Then what? We just hope it doesn't write something worse?

Miren's eyes harden.

MIREN
No. We make it choke. On something it didn't write.

A beat.

Koa shifts, voice low, nearly to himself.

KOA
For once.

The map in the sand burns faint with lingering feather-glow.

Carter stands, slowly, eyes sweeping the space.

- Miren's rough sketch carved into the soot.

- Leo's feather, glowing faintly.

- The ember under Miren's collar.

- His siblings' bruised faces.

- Koa, hunched but listening, jaw clenched like he's holding the whole room's silence.

CARTER
(speaking without weight)
We can run.
(beat)
Pray this chapter holds long enough to find a door that leads out, not deeper in.

He lifts his gaze.

CARTER (CONT'D)
Or we go to the Heart.

Burn the ending it wants for us.

A pause—then:

CARTER (CONT'D)
I'm not deciding that alone this time.

Ava still holds her scrap drawing—three silhouettes, smudged but whole. Her fingers tremble around it.

She looks at LEO. Then Carter. Then the sketch again.

AVA
If we live...
(beat)
I want something that's not just this.

She swallows.

AVA (CONT'D)
I want to wake up and draw things that don't end in blood.

A beat. Her voice steadies.

AVA (CONT'D)
I don't want the ending the Book showed me.

I want mine. (beat) So I'm in.

All eyes land on Leo.

He doesn't look away this time. Just breathes. Once. Twice.

LEO
It's always going to want me.
(soft)
That's not changing.

A glance at Miren. At Ava's drawing. Then the feather in his palm, glowing like a memory that won't be erased.

LEO (CONT'D)
If it's going to write something about me...

I want to be the one holding the pen. (beat) I want to look her in the face and say my name.

Miren kneels beside Koa again. He's not fully present, but she takes his hand—his fingers twitch, then tighten around hers.

KOA
(quiet)
You get to pick this time.
(beat)
I'll hold whatever line I can.

MIREN
Then we go to the Heart.

The sixth feather dims to a steady glow in Leo's hand. The fifth warms, slow and sure, beneath Miren's collar.

A low, distant thrum ripples through the ground. Not loud. But unmistakable.

The Book has felt them choose.

They stand. All of them.

Scarred. Awake. Unwritten.

CUT TO:

INT. CHAPTER'S HEART - HOLLOW CARNIVAL - "NIGHT / NO-TIME"

A narrowing corridor of BOOKSHELVES stretches ahead, bent like ribs, paper-bound and pulsing faintly.

Ava, Carter, and Leo move in tandem. Miren leads, the fifth feather embered beneath her collar. Koa limps, half strength, his every step a battle.

A half-dozen THREAD-RUNNER SURVIVORS follow close, battered, silent. One bleeds through a fresh rib bandage. Another clutches a torn, ink-stained BANNER, shaking.

Around them, the corridor WARPS.

BOOKSHELVES curl into faded midway GATES. Ink-lanterns hang like hollowed-out skulls of stories. Their flames sputter with breathless light.

Overhead, the air vibrates with the broken pulse of a CALLIOPE, fractured, uneven.

Every time the tune stutters, Koa FLINCHES, white-ink twitch crawling up his neck.

They press forward.

A final arch of shelves. Then—

THEY STEP INTO— THE HOLLOW CARNIVAL.

An arena of sagging TENTS and shattered RIDES. The ground is pulp and dirt, heavy with ghost footprints.

Rides twist skyward like broken punctuation. Carousels spin in silence. Ferris wheels breathe ink.

Carter clocks the warped silhouette of the tent where Leo vanished that first night.

Ava freezes, eyes on a shattered SWING RIDE, one they never dared go near. Its seats hang empty, swinging over a page-pit.

Leo finds the BOOK TENT, a breathing silhouette, each exhale synced to the calliope's gasping notes.

The THREAD-RUNNERS spread, quietly reverent.

ONE THREAD-RUNNER
(whispers)
This is as close as we've ever gotten.

Another checks a blade with shaking hands, eyes fixed on the BIG TOP ahead.

MIREN
This is it. This chapter's where it decided what to make of you.

LEO
Not this time.

Carter tightens his grip around the SPINE STAFF. Ava edges closer to Leo.

KOA slows, feather dagger in hand. Breath ragged. He stares at the Big Top recognizing the road that ruined him.

He says nothing. But we feel the choice in him.

Together— THEY WALK TOWARD THE BIG TOP.

Its canvas rises and falls. A living heart. Waiting.

INT. BIG TOP - CHAPTER'S HEART - NIGHT/NO-TIME - CONTINUOUS

The entrance flaps whip and snap behind them as they cross in.

INSIDE: a circular tent—but no canvas above. The ceiling is torn open to a blank, colorless sky. Pale and infinite. Empty. Waiting.

Surrounding them: the stands. Roped-off benches fade into darkness, filled with SHADOWY FIGURES—static silhouettes flickering like damaged film, caught between frames. Unfinished. Forgotten.

AT CENTER: a low pedestal, ringed in sand and paper. Hovering above it, a HALF-WRITTEN PAGE drips words like ink-tears—phrases crawl and rearrange themselves but never settle. Never end.

The glow of the siblings' feathers dims.

A beat of silence.

LEO flinches. The tent seems smaller now—closer.

The lights flicker.

MOTION in the stands— The SHADOWS solidify into FACES. Not whole, but real enough to hurt: A BOY in a varsity jacket. A NURSE with ink trailing from her mouth. A COP whose face glitches between two memories. A TEEN in a hoodie. A MOTHER. A CHILD.

The FORGOTTEN.

CARTER’s hand tightens on his staff.

LEO takes a step closer to his siblings.

KOA’s jaw clenches. His free hand curls near the dagger at his side.

A FLICKER—
And at the far edge of the ring:

The EXECUTIONER steps into view.

Cloaked in torn pages. A mask of pale parchment stitched across her face. The FEATHER-KNIFE glints in one hand—slick with memory.

Her voice is layered—deep and distant. Beneath the Book’s voice, a buried echo: Anna.

EXECUTIONER
Every story needs an ending.
Yours ran its course. Time to come
back to the page.

CARTER doesn't move. But his eyes flicker. Recognition. Pain. Just for a breath.

A still beat.

Somewhere, the scratch of a pen.

Then—

The crowd of FORGOTTEN drop from the stands like ink spilled across parchment—

They rush the siblings.

The air SHUDDERS with half-screamed lines: "—wasn't finished—" "—she promised I'd be remembered—" "—he never came back—"

Hands stretch. Fingers ink-smudged. Movements jerky but hungry.

AVA, Grabs a broken support pole from the ground—spins it into a defensive stance.

CARTER, Lowers into a fighter's crouch. Staff raised. Eyes locked.

LEO, Nearly stumbles as a SHADOW-HAND swipes his arm...MIREN, snatches him back just in time.

KOA, Groans as his knees almost give— Then forces himself upright, dagger flashing to life in his hand. He turns to face the charge—

FIRST IMPACT—

The clash hits.

The siblings brace.

Ink meets skin.

Memory meets will.

INT. BIG TOP - THE RING - NIGHT/NO-TIME

A flurry of movement.

QUICK CUTS —

AVA ducks a swinging arm — cracks her pole against a shadow's shoulder. She twists, eyes scanning — searching.

MIREN sidesteps, rolls — disables a Forgotten with precision, knocking it cold, not dead. Her face grim. Controlled. She doesn't look at Carter.

KOA slashes through ink and motion — but he's off-tempo. A breath behind. One hit nearly drops him. He recovers, barely.

CARTER

Whirls — blocked — struck — thrown back—

—SLAMS into the sand near the edge of the ring. Wind knocked out.

He blinks up—

A SHADOW FIGURE steps forward.

Small. Still. Head bowed. Ink running from her fingers, dripping like rain.

Hair veils her face.

She doesn't charge. Just stands there. Watching.

Carter doesn't move.

He knows that posture.

His breath catches. His feet twitch—almost turning—

A voice — low, inside him — not his own:

EXECUTIONER (V.O.)
You could run again. The story forgives repetition. It loves patterns.

His throat tightens.

He pushes back with his hands, starts to rise—

Then stops.

He looks at the girl.

The rain drips off her silhouette. Waiting.

His hands tremble. He stays on one knee.

CARTER
(soft, barely a whisper)
I left you. I ran. I'm not running this time.

The shadow stirs. Her face lifts— FLASH: for half a second, it's HER.

The real girl. Soaked. Eyes wide. A flicker of peace. A flicker of recognition.

She reaches forward, her ink-stained hand brushes Carter's cheek.

Then: She dissolves. Not in a fall—but a rise, an ink-mist drifting upward. Weightless.

Carter doesn't move. He just breathes. His feet still planted. His choice made.

INT. BIG TOP - CENTER RING - NO-TIME

The shadows are still reeling—shattered into coils of ink. But it's not over.

CARTER
Staggers backward from the memory-girl's disappearance—eyes flicking to his hand.

The OATHBOUND GLYPH burns.

Lines tighten—pulse—then shift.

What was once a knot of chains becomes a wide circle—joined by three open lines. Breathing.

He flexes his fingers.

Instead of feeling bound—he feels... tethered.

Alive.

Nearby—

The ink roils. Rises.

A SCREECH—low, guttural, metallic.

From the edge of the ring, something massive UNFURLS.

A BEAST—
Wrought from broken ferris wheel bones and torn tent-canvas, stitched with rusted ride gears, clawed limbs of twisted iron, and a spine coiled in pages. Its eyes drip ink.

It turns—

Goes straight for LEO.

Then CARTER.

AVA FREEZES.

This is the shape of her nightmare. Losing them. Again.

She could throw herself in front of it.

Old pattern.

Instead—

She moves.

Not between. But beside.

AVA
(soft)
No more monsters.

She lifts her hand—

From her sleeve: a crumpled corner of drawing paper. Her own lines. Her own rules.

She grips it—then traces into the air. Jagged, fast strokes.

A design—not of defense, but of fracture.

A BREAKPOINT drawn straight through the beast's spine.

The ink-beast SHRIEKS—

Its form stutters—

Then JERKS—

SNAPS along the line she drew.

A violent fold inward. It collapses.

AVA stumbles.

Hands ink-streaked. Chest heaving.

LEO (O.S.)
You broke it.

She looks up—

Her brothers at her side now.

Not behind her. Not needing rescue.

Together.

She stares at her hands.

AVA
I didn’t fight it.
(beat)
I changed it.

The last wisps of the creature dissolve—rising, not falling.

INT. BIG TOP - CHAPTER'S HEART - NO-TIME

The battle roars, ink screams and memory-blood on paper floors.

IN THE RING—

The siblings fight back-to-back. AVA bruised. LEO panting. CARTER holding them steady.

But MIRREN, breaks off, eyes locked on the shape beyond them:

THE EXECUTIONER.

They move. Toward each other. Not fast—but inevitable.

CLOSE QUARTERS:

Feather-knife clashes with stolen blade—paper-slick steel against soul-callused hands.

Miren drives forward. Not wild. Not reckless. Precise. Determined.

EXECUTIONER
You were written as an orphan. Stop trying to edit.

Miren’s blade sparks—pushes the Executioner back.

MIRREN
Then I’ll rewrite what comes next.

Another strike. Another dodge. The clash isn’t clean, it’s personal.

A twist— The feather-knife FLIES, knocked from the Executioner’s grip.

Her mask CRACKS down the center— A breath of real skin beneath.

Everyone freezes. Even the Book hushes—like it’s *waiting*.

Miren steps forward.

Her hand trembles—not from fear. From knowing.

She pulls the POCKET WATCH from beneath her coat.

Opens it. Inside: the image of a man, a girl, and a woman—smiling.

She presses it gently to the fracture.

MIRREN (SOFT) (CONT'D)
Mom.

The Executioner stumbles— A shuddering inhale—

Her mask GLITCHES—flickers—

ANNA'S EYES. Wet. Human. Terrified.

For one breathless beat—she is there.

Then—

BOOK'S VOICE (O.S.) / EXECUTIONER (OVERLAYING)
Hunter. Take them. Restore order.

ACROSS THE RING—

KOA freezes mid-swing.

His body locks. Eyes go glassy—

He turns—slowly—toward the kids. Predator-quiet. Hunter-cold.

LEO sees it— Staggers back.

MIREN sees it—

MIRREN
Koa. Look at me. You are not its hunter. You're ours.

Koa twitches—snarls—like something *breaking loose* inside.

The Book pushes harder— But Koa *refuses*.

He turns— And DRIVES his blade into a knot of shadow-souls converging on the siblings.

Ink screams. Paper tears.

KOA
I hunt for them. Not you.

INT. BIG TOP - CHAPTER'S HEART - NO-TIME

A NEW SOUND—

High-pitched chittering. Threads straining. A seam pulling open.

The THREAD-RUNNERS emerge.

SKITTERING out of cracks in the earth. SLIDING down ruined tent-poles. SWINGING across torn beams like silk-strung spiders.

They weave themselves between the siblings and the Forgotten—forming luminous thread-barriers, vibrating with unseen tension.

A SHOUT—
RESISTANCE SURVIVORS—faces grim, bodies bruised—pour through the chaos, flanking the Thread-Runners, weapons raised.

The battlefield shifts. From doomed... to barely survivable.

In the ring—

The EXECUTIONER falters.

The flicker of Anna’s eyes still burning behind her mask. Her body glitches between enforcer and mother. The FEATHER-KNIFE lowers—then lifts again, hesitant.

MIREN presses forward.

KOA turns, defending the kids with clean, brutal strikes. No longer a Hunter. Their shield.

And then—

A deep, RUMBLING TEAR.

THE TENT WALLS begin to PEEL UPWARD— Like someone turning a page.

Sand lifts in spiral streams. Paper torn from the ground TWISTS into a rising funnel. The stands COLLAPSE— One by one— Exploding into LETTERS that scatter like birds.

THE SKY—
Still blank.

But now—

CRACKS begin to spider across it, thin black ink-lines splitting the white.

MIREN (BREATHLESS)
It’s closing the chapter. If it can’t get its ending—
(beat)
—it’ll bury us with it.

The wind HOWLS.

The earth CURLS inward.

And at the eye of it all—

The three siblings.

CARTER, AVA, and LEO fall into instinct—

Back-to-back at the ring’s center. CARTER’s Oath glyph BURNS against his palm. AVA’s fingers still clutch her scrap of the drawing. LEO, smaller, breathing fast—

Looks UP.

Not at the chaos— At the blank sky.

It waits.

Every chapter he’s seen ends the same— a line written across the heavens.

But not this one.

Above them: only silence. Paper-white.

LEO (QUIET)
It hasn’t ended yet.

And beneath them—

THE WORLD BEGINS TO BREAK.

INT. BIG TOP - CHAPTER'S HEART - NO-TIME

Chaos swirls—thread-runners scuttling, souls unraveling, the sky above splintering like shattered porcelain.

LEO (SHOUTING)
It doesn’t have an ending yet!

CARTER
Leo, stay down!

AVA
What are you doing?!

LEO steps forward—past the broken pedestal, into the precise center of the ring.

His fingers lift— and from them, ink coils.

Like smoke. Like memory.

The last FEATHER is gone. The ink answers to him now.

Across the battlefield— The EXECUTIONER SCREAMS—lunging toward him.

But— Koa intercepts. Sword drawn. Bracing. Miren is there too—striking fast, holding the line.

Leo doesn’t look. He lifts his hand— and writes.

Each stroke blazes across the blank sky like fire in ink:

THIS STORY BELONGS TO THE ONES WHO LIVED IT.

A pulse. A snap.

The Book lurches—

The entire chapter buckles sideways, groaning like a sinking ship.

At the pedestal— the HALF-WRITTEN PAGE shreds apart. Its words scatter.

And in the sky—

a SEAM OPENS.

Not an ending. A rupture.

A vertical TEAR of ink and light rips through the sky above the ring— a vortex howling with pages and memory.

The Executioner reels back, sucked slightly toward the tear, clawing for grip, still trying to reach Leo, but the forgotten souls begin to dissolve upward. Unwritten. Unanchored.

Mirens's voice, shouted over the roar:

MIREN
You broke its ending.

The sky flickers, but the portal holds.

Leo stands beneath it. Arm still outstretched.

Ink burning on his hand.

CUT TO:

INT. DERELICT HOUSE - EDGE OF TOWN - NIGHT

Silence.

The same broken house from earlier—its edges fraying now, like memory rotting at the seams. Light seeps through cracks in the boarded windows, flickering like a dying projector.

Stacks of worn notebooks. Ink-stained mugs. Torn sketches of doorways and feathers scattered across the floor.

On the table: the BOOK. Shut. Still. Heavy as guilt.

GIDEON slumps in a chair across from it—gray-skinned, hollow-eyed. His hands tremble with each breath. He coughs, ragged and wet, into his sleeve.

Not dying. Decaying.

He reaches for a crumpled page nearby—scribbled fragments of a letter never sent. Ink scrawls like spider legs across it.

Then—the ink shifts.

Lines melt and rearrange.

The page becomes a drawing.

Crude. Bold. Real.

A FEATHER.

Three CHILDREN drawn in black strokes. A FOURTH FIGURE, half-finished.

A voice—MIREN'S—faint, braided with memory, crosses the room like wind through cracked glass.

MIREN (V.O.)
We're still here. We're not finished.

Gideon stares.

His hand hovers above the paper, just short of touching it.

Tears slip down his face without sound.

He looks to the BOOK again. It does not move. Does not hum. It fears him now.

And he understands.

Opening it won't bring them back. It will end him.

He looks again at the drawing. The unfinished figure.

A whisper, to the page. To the air. To her.

GIDEON
You're asking me to help you leave…
(beat)
Not to come back.

His hand lowers.

Fingertips hover over the cover of the Book.

INT. DERELICT HOUSE - EDGE OF TOWN - REAL WORLD - NIGHT

Gideon sits hunched at the table, breath shallow, hands trembling above the Book.

He exhales.

GIDEON
Okay. For you.

He SLAMS both palms on the covers and THROWS them open.

A VIOLENT GALE of ink and white light erupts from the Book's core— PAPERS whip like birds startled from roost.

Cracks in the rotting walls split with LIGHT.

Streaks of inkfire RACE into the night.

CUT TO:

INT. HOLLOW CARNIVAL - CHAPTER'S HEART - CONTINUOUS

THE SKY-SLASH burns HOTTER above Leo’s head—

THE INK-LINE he wrote glows like a living wound, then SPASMS—splitting wider, more vertical.

The VORTEX is no longer abstract. It is a SHAPED EXIT.

A PORTAL.

GRAVITY tilts.

THE ENTIRE CARNIVAL shifts toward the rift.

Thread-Runners skitter. Miren throws a hand out to steady Leo.

Shadow-forms spiral upward in ribbons.

MIREN
Someone’s opening it from the other side.

The Book itself is being pulled apart.

CUT TO:

THE EXECUTIONER—

Body twitching, mask FLUTTERING through identities like wind-ripped flags.

She FREEZES.

A NEW VOICE slides from her throat.

Not Anna.

THE BOOK / STORYWRIGHT (V.O. THROUGH HER)
No. This chapter closes as written.

Her feather-knife EXTENDS—a blade of page-edges, a line-break turned into a weapon.

She SPRINTS toward the PORTAL—

Wind RAGES around her.

INTENT clear:

SLASH the seam shut.

SMASH TO BLACK.

EXT. HOLLOW CARNIVAL - PORTAL LANE - STORY WORLD

The space between the kids and the rip in the sky becomes a crucible.

Sand tears sideways. Paper flays upward.

FORGOTTEN SOULS spiral like torn film.

The EXECUTIONER drives forward—no longer a person, but a weapon, a jagged streak of ink and blade.

BOOK (V.O.)
Hunter. Guard the ending.

KOA jerks like he's been struck in the spine. His legs buckle.

His eyes glaze. His breath stutters.

That old training surges up inside him—the Hunter's role branded deep in his marrow.

He stumbles forward.

Reflex. Instinct.

KOA steps between the EXECUTIONER and the portal lane.

But—

He doesn't move. He twitches.

One moment, his weapon arcs toward the children— The next, toward the charging blade.

BOOK (V.O.) (THROUGH KOA)
Stand down.

His own voice betrays him.

Mirrored light pulses around his weapon—like it, too, is confused who to serve.

MIREN (O.S.)
Koa!

He falters.

MIREN (CONT'D)
You don't belong to it. You never did.

KOA gasps like surfacing from deep water. His weapon hand shakes violently.

One stance: precise, lethal, inhuman. The other: raw, uncentered, deeply human.

He glances back—sees LEO clutching the burning feather, AVA with her fractured drawing, CARTER braced in front of them.

The last remnants of the world peel away around them.

The EXECUTIONER explodes forward.

KOA plants his feet—like he did on the bridge. But this time, he knows exactly who he's standing for.

KOA
I'm done hunting for you.

He hurls himself at the EXECUTIONER.

Blade meets blade. Fury meets defiance.

KOA shoves her weapon sideways, diverting her arc.

She misses the portal's seam by inches.

The two of them lock there, frontline of the last stand.

KOA, no longer the Book's hunter.

Just a man standing between a story and its ending.

EXT. HOLLOW CARNIVAL - PORTAL LANE - STORY WORLD

Chaos.

The sky roars above—a vertical wound of ink and white light, unstable, thrashing. Forgotten souls spiral toward it like embers in a funnel. The chapter unravels around them.

In the center of it all, KOA and THE EXECUTIONER clash.

Their blades meet in violent arcs, each strike lighting the space with inkshock and shuddering gravity. Koa fights with raw instinct, wounded strength. He's not fast anymore. But he's furious.

EXECUTIONER
You were written as my blade.

KOA
(driven, defiant)
Then I'm rewriting it.

A beat—

The Executioner feints low, then spins her blade in a tight arc—

—SLAASH. It catches KOA across the ribs. He hits one knee hard, gasping, weapon knocked free. Blood runs, too dark for real blood.

The Executioner raises her page-edged feather-knife. Her target is unclear: Koa's throat, or the seam in the portal behind him.

A flash of motion—

MIREN throws herself in, between them.

KOA (CONT'D)
Miren, no—

MIREN
(steady, fire in her voice)
I am not leaving you behind again.

She holds the pocket watch in a death grip, arm trembling. The ticking cuts through the sound like a heartbeat in an empty room.

The Executioner lunges—

Miren doesn't flinch. She lunges too—

—and SLAMS the watch against the cracks in the Executioner's mask.

Silence.

The world pulls taut.

A loud, single tick.

MIREN (CONT'D)
(not a plea—a truth)
Mom.

The mask fractures with a brittle gasp.

Pages peel away, like wet bandages.

And beneath—

ANNA'S FACE. Human. Real. Tear-streaked, shaking.

The feather-knife wavers.

Her eyes find Miren's.

Recognition. Horror. Love. All in one breathless beat.

And the two of them just stare.

MOTHER.

DAUGHTER.

Connected finally through the one truth the Book never scripted.

CUT TO:

EXT. DERELICT HOUSE - EDGE OF TOWN - REAL WORLD - NIGHT

A low wind rattles the windows.

INT. DERELICT HOUSE - SAME - REAL WORLD

The BOOK lies open on the table, its pages fluttering like lungs gasping. GIDEON stands over it, hands braced on either side, body trembling.

INK crawls up his arms like black veins.

Flashes:

-- ANNA laughing, brushing flour from her nose.

-- Little MIREN dancing, wild and joyful, in socks on the hardwood.

-- The first time Gideon opened the Book. The look in his eyes.

Back in the room—

Gideon's fingers twitch. His jaw trembles. But he's not afraid.

He feels it: a hand interlaced with his.

Not real—but real enough. Anna’s hand. Warm. Home.

Gideon closes his eyes.

More flashes:

-- A family dinner. Candlelight. Laughter.

-- A rainstorm. Anna and Miren dancing on the porch.

-- A night where no one spoke, but everything was understood.

He opens his eyes. Breathes in.

GIDEON
Okay. For you.

He presses both palms to the open Book.

WHOOSH—

A ROAR of light and ink surges out. The walls pulse with veins of energy. Pages whip into a cyclone. The air splits.

SMASH TO:

INT. HOLLOW CARNIVAL - CHAPTER'S HEART

LEO’S BURNING LINE across the sky WIDENS—

The tear becomes a clean, vertical wound: a PORTAL of white and ink. Not elegant. Not scripted. Ripped open.

The ground TREMBLES. The air warps.

CUT TO:

INT. DERELICT HOUSE - NIGHT - REAL WORLD

Gideon’s skin pales. The ink swallows him inch by inch. But his expression is calm.

GIDEON
(softly, to the Book)
I’ll take the ending.

The ink consumes him—

A final flash: Anna and Miren, side by side, sunlight behind them.

His eyes close. Peaceful.

The Book SLAMS SHUT.

CUT TO:

INT. HOLLOW CARNIVAL - CHAPTER'S HEART

The PORTAL stabilizes. No more flickering—just blinding light and clean ink edges. The gravity shifts.

The Forgotten Souls spiral upward faster.

The wind changes.

A current opens through the collapsing chaos. A path.

Koa steadies himself. Ava grabs Carter and Leo’s arm.

The Executioner stumbles, momentarily disarmed.

Miren doesn’t hesitate.

MIREN
GO!

EXT. HOLLOW CARNIVAL - CHAPTER'S HEART - NIGHT

The sky has ripped wide. A VERTICAL SEAM of SEARING WHITE and INK now blazes open in the air above the tented ruins. The portal.

Time stutters. The collapsing world hangs mid-unravel.

Tattered walls of the Carnival flutter like caught breath. Forgotten SOULS spiral upward into the tear, not screaming—just leaving, like smoke rising through light.

A LOW ROAR pulses beneath it all. A rhythmic TICKING creeps in, steady and strange. Anna's watch. Echoing.

GIDEON (O.S.)
(so faint, it could be memory)
I'll take the ending.

MIREN freezes—soul catching up to time.

MIREN
That’s it.
(then louder, eyes wide)
That’s the way out.

KOA staggers beside her, ink trailing from an old wound. He squints toward the portal.

KOA
(shouting over the wind)
Whatever he did—he can't hold it forever!

The wind changes direction. Not chaos now. A pull.

LEO stares at his hands—INK-MOTES lifting off his skin, pulled toward the light.

AVA clutches her SCRAP DRAWING to her chest, knuckles white.

CARTER's OATH GLYPH burns faintly on his forearm. He looks at the other two, instinct kicking in: big brother mode. Protect. Move.

MIREN grabs AVA's shoulder, pulls her closer.

MIREN
You want your own ending?
(beat)
That's where you run.

THE EXECUTIONER lurches in the background—disoriented, glitched, momentarily unable to intercept.

The THREAD-RUNNERS—those who still stand—begin to MOVE, weaving through the debris. A FRAGILE CORRIDOR forms.

KOA turns, plants his feet, raises a blade slick with storyblood.

KOA
GO!

The camera snaps to the SIBLINGS, one breath, three hearts, and the path before them.

They run.

EXT. HOLLOW CARNIVAL - CHAPTER'S HEART - NIGHT

The PORTAL blazes like a split sun in the ink-ripped sky. Wind howls. Time stutters.

CARTER, AVA, and LEO sprint forward—shoulder-to-shoulder. Carter leads for a breath—then checks himself. Drops back into line with them. No one gets left behind.

Around them: FORGOTTEN SOULS swirl, not attacking but reaching, mournful. THREAD-RUNNERS dive in from the sides, knocking away grasping ink-limbs. Every second counts.

They close in on the base of the PORTAL—

—when a jagged WAVE OF SHADOW-SOULS bursts from the side—

Ink tendrils SNAP around LEO—ankles, wrists, throat.

He’s YANKED sideways off his feet.

CARTER
Leo!

Carter lunges after him, trying to wrench him free. AVA skids in the sand, face wild.

AVA
Let him go!

But the Book remembers this pattern. The siblings fleeing. One being pulled back.

Leo STRUGGLES, half-pinned, pulled down into the sand and shadow. The void hungers.

CARTER’S hand still on Leo’s wrist. AVA grabs his other.

But Leo meets their eyes.

LEO
(fierce, breaking)
I’m not staying. Not again.

He twists, a sharp, wrong-angle move. The Book glitches around it.

The INK THREADS tear.

Carter and Ava HAUL him out together. And they run.

The three of them hurtle toward the PORTAL together.

INT. HOLLOW CARNIVAL - CHAPTER'S HEART

The seam of light looms—no longer a wound but a gate, blazing white and ink-bound at the center of the collapsing chapter.

CARVED INK and FOLDING PAGES spiral overhead as the ground fractures beneath.

CARTER, AVA, and LEO break into their final sprint. Carter leads for half a beat—then slows just enough to match their stride. The three lock shoulders.

Their last steps are chaotic—sand flays upward, shadows claw behind them—

—and then they LEAP INTO THE LIGHT.

INT. PORTAL SPACE - BETWEEN

Time warps. Bodies stretch like ink on wet parchment. Bones echo. Veins glow.

Muffled voices. Ticking hearts.

Then—

The white swallows them.

EXT. CHAPTER'S HEART - REMAINING

The silhouettes of the three siblings vanish into the tear.

MIREN stands frozen—half-hope, half-loss flickering in her chest.

Koa is down on one knee, shoulder bleeding, weapon black and slick in the inkstorm.

The PORTAL FLICKERS.

The tent above SCREAMS—its walls tearing skyward in violent spirals.

THREAD-RUNNERS shout in the distance as the ground begins to split. The chapter is unraveling fast.

Koa grabs Miren’s wrist.

KOA
Go. You’ve done enough.

Miren rips her arm back.

MIREN
Not leaving you behind again.

She hooks an arm under his, dragging him upright. He flinches, but lets her.

KOA
You don’t have to—

MIREN
I am.

The two lurch into motion, sprinting toward the last light—

—and the BOOK STRIKES BACK.

A tremor splits the Heart.

ABOVE: ENORMOUS TRANSLUCENT PAGES SNAP SHUT, one by one.

Each page is edged in BONED BINDINGS, slamming down like jaws.

The portal begins to CLOSE, shrinking from a seam to a slit.

The wind howls backward.

Koa and Miren run harder as the tear of light narrows.

INT. HOLLOW CARNIVAL - CHAPTER'S HEART - CONTINUOUS

A ragged wind howls through the torn remains of the world.

The PORTAL SEAM is closing—no longer a wide tear, but a needle-thin slit of white and ink, just barely wide enough for one.

Koa and Miren skid to the base of the collapsing light, shoulder to shoulder.

KOA
On three. Don’t look back.

MIREN
(sharp)
Shut up and jump with me.

They lock eyes. No time for more.

They leap—

—Miren hits first, her hand breaching the portal, skin bathed in light—

—Koa’s hand still inside, caught in ink and static.

He grimaces, feeling the pull. The Book coils around his wrist like a leash.

The instinct to hold on kicks in.

Just one tug could pull her back. Keep her. Just this once—

Instead—he shoves.

KOA
(gritted)
Go.

The push drives her deeper into the light—but drags his own shoulder back into the Book.

Miren twists. Her hand finds his wrist again—fierce.

MIREN
(through teeth)
I told you. I'm not leaving you.

Their grip clenches—then—

THE VAULT SLAMS SHUT.

A blinding flash.

The world inhales—

And collapses.

On the Book's side:

The portal seam snaps like a closing wound. Light gone. Ink devouring.

The VAULT'S PAGES, massive and bone-lined, crash together with finality, sealing the Heart.

Dust, memory, silence.

And from somewhere else—

—Outside time, outside page—

Two figures. Thread-silhouettes. Suspended.

Not crushed. Not erased.

Falling sideways, into the dark.

CUT TO:

EXT. WOODS - DAWN

FADE IN:

Soft, pale morning light filters through skeletal trees. A faint breeze rustles the leaves. Birds call in the distance. There is no sound of ink, no scream of closing chapters—only wind and breath.

CARTER lies on his back in a bed of damp leaf litter.

His shirt is torn, his skin smeared with ink and dirt. His right hand still twitches, clenched like he's braced for an impact that never came.

A few feet away:

AVA sprawled on her side, one arm flung across the earth like she was reaching for someone. Hair matted, body slack.

LEO lies half-curled, knees tucked, as if trying to make himself small against a fall.

They are still.

Then—

CARTER'S EYES SNAP OPEN.

He bolts upright, gasping, every muscle tight. For a second, he doesn’t see trees. He sees tents. Ink. Screaming.

But there is only forest.

Cold air ghosts across his face. The ash and fire are gone. In their place: early morning quiet. A faint clearing up ahead—a ring of trampled leaves where once a carnival stood.

Carter exhales, shuddering.

He spins, searching—

CARTER
(panic)
AVA.
LEO.

He crawls, knees grinding against roots and dirt, toward the still forms.

He shakes Ava first.

CARTER (CONT'D)
Ava—hey, hey—come on—

Her eyelids flutter. She inhales sharply, sits up too fast—

AVA
Wha—ugh—

She winces, clutches her side.

She sees Carter. Sees the forest. Realizes.

AVA (CONT'D)
We're out.

Carter nods, a breathy, broken sound catching in his throat.

Leo stirs. Blinks at the light. Sky.

He scrambles upright, breath catching when he sees them both.

LEO
You're—you're okay.

They huddle for a moment, silent, too wrung out for anything but presence.

Then—a hush.

Carter turns his head.

There, a few feet away, nestled in the leaves: The BOOK. Closed. Motionless. No glow, no pulse. Just paper and leather, half-covered in leaf litter. Waiting.

They stare at it. Breathing. No one moves.

INT. WOODS - DAWN

The trees hold their breath. Soft mist floats through shafts of early light. A hush, broken only by breath and birdsong.

CARTER sits hunched near the closed Book, but doesn't touch it. He looks to AVA, then LEO.

CARTER
Are you okay? Anything broken?

AVA winces as she rotates her shoulder. Her breath catches—then evens.

AVA
Everything hurts. So... normal?

It’s not a real joke, but her mouth twitches. She's not running from herself this time.

Leo sits cross-legged, eyes on his hands. Ink threads faintly shimmer across his forearms—fading.

LEO
I’m... here. All of me.

The Book sits there, flecked with pine and dirt. Waiting.

Silence.

Then—

CARTER
We made it out.
(beat)
What do you guys want to do?

A beat. Ava looks at Leo. Leo looks back. The question lands. Carter isn’t leading. He’s listening.

AVA
(eyes locked on it)
We should... throw it in a river.

CARTER doesn’t answer.

AVA (CONT’D)
Or burn it. Bury it. Nuke it. I don’t care. Just—

LEO
(shaking his head)
We tried destroying it from the inside.
(beat)
It didn’t die. It just... changed.

Not defensive. Just the truth.

CARTER
If we leave it here, someone else finds it.

A beat.

AVA
I don’t want it anywhere near us.

Her voice trembles at the edges. This isn’t strategy it’s fear. PTSD bleeding through the cracks.

LEO
Miren and Koa are still in there.

The names hit the air like stones dropped in water.

Silence.

CARTER
It’s not done with us. That rule... you saw it.
(then)
But maybe that’s not a curse. Maybe it’s just... true.

All three look at the Book.

CARTER turns to AVA.

CARTER (CONT’D)
We don’t have to open it. Ever. But if it’s going to be in this world I’d rather it be somewhere we can watch it.

AVA glares at him. Swallows.

AVA
(small, bitter)
I hate that you’re right.

LEO
We take it. We hide it.
(soft)
And we decide if it opens again. Not it.

CARTER watches AVA.

She hesitates... then gives a tiny, reluctant:

AVA
Fine. But it goes in the darkest closet we can find.

A hush. A breath held by the world.

Above the closed BOOK, the air warps softly—as if exhaling ink. Motes rise like fireflies, drifting upward in curls of black shimmer.

In midair, a SENTENCE BEGINS TO FORM—

Written in that same familiar, eerie script: “Those who escape must one day return…” It HANGS. The ink twitching, “…or the story collapses.”

The words linger, then DISSOLVE into mid air.

Carter, Ava, and Leo stare.

A beat.

AVA (CONT’D)
(soft, bitter laugh)
It’s still bossy.

LEO
It’s a rule.

Doesn’t mean we go back now.

CARTER
We went back once because we didn’t have a choice. Next time, if there is one...
(beat)
It’s on our terms.

Nothing else is said. But it’s understood: They are free—for now.

CARTER steps forward. Slowly. Reaches down.

Lifts the Book with both hands, then TUCKS IT under his arm.

Ava groans, forces herself upright. She falters, Leo is already there. This time, she lets him help.

Carter starts forward.

Leo flanks his other side.

Three siblings. Bruised. Whole.

They walk through the trees.

AHEAD, The blurred shimmer of a small town in the distance. A road. Maybe the beginning of something ordinary.

Where the Book lay: Only a TRACE OF ASH remains.

The wind stirs. Carries it away.

WIDE SHOT: Three figures. Dwarfed by the forest.

But together.

FADE TO BLACK.

Title card: EIGHT MONTHS LATER

EXT. SMALL TOWN STREET - DAY

A bright, ordinary afternoon. Kids pedal bikes down cracked sidewalks. A car honks, someone waves. Life, moving forward.

INT. COFFEE SHOP - DAY

AVA sits alone at a back table, sketchbook open. Her pencil glides across the page—not drawing monsters, but people in a park. Trees. Motion. Warmth.

The barista drops off a tea.

BARISTA
(soft)
Still at it?

Ava gives a small smile, flips the page like it's nothing. Then, she flips back. Keeps going.

INT. COMMUNITY COLLEGE BULLETIN BOARD - DAY

Carter pins a flyer to the corkboard. His hand still bears the faint glyph of the Oath—but it's nearly vanished now.

A COWORKER (20s) leans in with a teasing grin.

COWORKER
You coming out with us tonight?

CARTER
(maybe too quick)
Can't—
(stops himself)
...Maybe. Yeah. Maybe.

He shrugs. The coworker grins and walks off. Carter doesn't chase. Doesn't overthink.

EXT. MODEST RENTAL HOUSE - DUSK

A two bedroom tucked behind trees. Laundry on the line. A chipped mailbox with no name.

INT. KITCHEN - SAME

Carter sorts through mail on the counter, flipping past a red notice with a flick of his thumb. No panic, just life.

Ava hums quietly, washing dishes with her sleeves rolled up. A phone plays soft indie music in the background.

LEO (O.S.)
(from the hallway)
I'm going to bed. Big test.

CARTER
You want help?

LEO
(sticking his head in)
I've got it.

Their eyes meet for a beat. Something unspoken. Carter lets it go.

INT. LEO'S ROOM - NIGHT

Clean, lived-in. A desk. A small bookshelf. A shared world slowly settling.

Leo shuts the door, peels off his hoodie, flops onto the bed.

He glances at a shelf where a plain box sits.

The Book. Wrapped in cloth, hidden. But there.

He exhales. Not in fear. Not in dread.

Just... weight.

He stares at the ceiling.

Still. Breathing.

A kid. And something more.

EXT. LEO'S ROOM - NIGHT

Silence. The hum of the fridge. The distant thrum of traffic through closed windows. A low lamp casts soft light across Leo's face as he lies on his back, eyes open but unfocused.

His eyelids droop.

His fingers twitch near the edge of the bed. The barest shimmer of fading ink-thread—like memory—ghosts over his knuckles.

CUT TO:

INT. VOID SPACE - DREAM

A deep midnight blue surrounds him, neither sky nor sea. Vast. Endless. Quiet.

Threads float around him like constellations, drifting in slow spirals. Some are light, some ink-dark. They pulse gently, like breathing.

Leo stands barefoot on nothing, steady.

His shoulders rise with a breath. Not afraid. Just… waiting.

Ahead, the threads stir. They draw inward, spinning tighter, starting to weave—

Until a silhouette begins to take shape: A GIRL formed of thread and light.

Not solid. Not fully rendered. A figure built of motion—every strand glimmering, shifting.

Her head tilts. A familiar angle. Echoes of a girl he met once, in the Book. But not quite her.

Her face is only light. No features. Just a pattern that moves like woven thought.

Her voice comes not from a mouth, but from the air—

GIRL OF THREAD (V.O.)
Unwritten one…

Leo doesn’t flinch.

He doesn’t speak yet, but his throat bobs with a swallow.

His gaze stays steady.

The threads between them shift, responding.

She lifts her hand.

GIRL OF THREAD (V.O.)
It’s breaking. We’re still here.

The dark behind her splits with a sharp fissure of light.

Through it: A glimpse of MIREN: hair loose, eyes defiant. KOA's silhouette: frayed at the edges, feather-knife glinting. A VAULT DOOR shakes violently, glowing at the seams.

The vision pulses, static and incomplete. Leo steps forward—

GIRL OF THREAD (V.O.)
We're not finished.

The fissure snaps shut. Threads unravel. Light collapses.

INT. LEO'S ROOM - NIGHT

Leo bolts upright, lungs heaving as the normal world rushes in.

He stares at his hand, a faint THREAD OF INK etched across his palm. Still wet.

He touches it. It smears, then disappears.

His gaze shifts to the closet.

The box that hides THE BOOK sits inert on the shelf.

...But for one heartbeat, a hairline crack of LIGHT glows at its seam. Then gone.

Leo swings his legs off the bed. Walks to the door. Opens it a crack.

Down the hall: Ava asleep on the couch, sketchbook open. A sliver of Carter's room, lamp now dark.

LEO
(whispers)
Miren...

He closes the door softly.

Back in bed, eyes open. Watching the ceiling.

In the far corner, a final glimmer of ink curls in the air and fades:

INK (V.O.)
...must one day return…

CUT TO BLACK.